

Nine councillors of MCD Standing Committee retire

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Nine councillors of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi's (MCD) Standing Committee retired on Tuesday following a draw of lots conducted during a meeting chaired by Standing Committee Chairperson Satya Sharma.

The retirements come as part of the statutory process under the Delhi Municipal Corporation (DMC) Act, which mandates periodic rotation of members. The Standing Committee comprises 18 councillors, of whom half retire at the end of their tenure through a draw of lots.

The process was carried out during an official meeting, where slips of paper on which councillors' names are written were drawn to determine the members completing their tenure. Chairperson Satya Sharma said the retiring members had played an important role in the func-



tioning of the corporation. "They contributed significantly during their tenure. We appreciate their work and wish them the best for the future," she said.

Out of the 12 members elected from ward committees, six councillors were selected for retirement through the draw. These include Ankush Narang from the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) and five Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) councillors: Shikha Bhardwaj, Inderjeet Sehrawat, Neema Bhagat, Rajpal Singh, and Anju Devi. In addition, three members

elected from the House also retired. These include AAP councillors Mohammad Aamil Malik and Mohini Jeenwal and BJP councillor Pankaj Luthra.

Officials said the process was conducted in accordance with established rules to ensure fairness and transparency. The draw of lots system is used to maintain rotational continuity within the Standing Committee.

The Standing Committee is one of the key decision-making bodies of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi. It is responsible for

financial approvals, policy decisions, and oversight of major civic works.

With the retirement of nine members, the process to induct new councillors into the committee is expected to begin soon.

Chairperson Sharma said the corporation will continue to function smoothly despite the changes. She expressed confidence that the induction of new members would strengthen the committee's work. "Under the leadership of the BJP government, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi will continue to function effectively. The committee will remain committed to public welfare and serving citizens," she said.

Officials noted that such periodic changes are essential to ensure broader participation of elected representatives in key civic bodies. The retiring members represented both the ruling BJP and the opposition AAP, reflecting the political composition of the civic body.

CM rejects claims of time limit on Saheli Pink Cards as complete lies

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Tuesday rejected claims that the 'Saheli Pink Card' for free bus travel to women residents can be used again only one hour after it has been tapped as "lies" and "propaganda".

She stressed that the new mobility cards are working with full efficiency, providing free travel to women and transgender residents of Delhi on buses.

"A rumour is being spread that if you tap your pink card once in a bus and then you get off and board another bus, then the card does not work. These are complete lies and political propaganda," she said in a video message in a post on X.

Earlier this month, the Pink National Common Mobility (PNCM) card was launched by President Droupadi Murmu. More than 1 lakh cards have been distributed till now, officials said.

The chief minister also said that travellers can use



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— REKHA GUPTA, CHIEF MINISTER

the Pink Card in "gaps of 5, 10 and 15 minutes" and that women can travel as many times as they want for free.

Under the scheme, the BJP government has replaced the pink paper ticketing system launched by the previous AAP government in 2019 by the Centre's 'One Nation, One Card' initiative through the Pink NCMC card, allowing free travel only for Delhi residents.

Chief Minister Gupta had said that the card will also enable seamless paid access to the Metro, Regional Rapid Transit System (RTS) and other public transport services through a single smart card. According to officials, the facility will be implemented on the same pattern and mechanism as the free travel scheme currently available for women passengers in Delhi buses.

Man stabbed to death by brother-in-law in Nand Nagri area

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 30-year-old man was stabbed to death by his brother-in-law following a family dispute in northeast Delhi's Nand Nagri area, an official said on Tuesday.

The incident came to light on the night of March 29 when police received information from GTB Hospital regarding the admission of an injured person with stab wounds, the officer said.

A police team rushed to the hospital, where the victim, Neeraj, a resident of Tahirpur, informed police that his brother-in-law stabbed him. Based on the information, the police registered a case at Nand Nagri police station and took up an investigation, the officer said.

The preliminary inquiry revealed that Neeraj had been attacked by his brother-in-law following a verbal altercation stemming from a family dispute, he said.



LG visits Kamla Nagar, asks women to email grievances

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Tuesday urged women to send their grievances through email with contact details, assuring them of follow-up action, during a visit to the Kamla Nagar market.

Interacting with locals in the north Delhi market, the LG said he had noted down concerns raised by several women and requested them to send a one-page email mentioning their name and contact number so that authorities could reach out to them directly.

He said feedback would be reviewed first, following which the complainants would be contacted and meetings would be held with the concerned officials to address the issues.

Emphasising collective

responsibility, Sandhu said joint efforts are required to improve Delhi, the national capital, and there was "no choice" in ensuring better civic conditions.

Referring to the broader vision of a developed India, he said Delhi had a crucial role to play and authorities must actively engage with residents to understand and resolve their problems.

During the visit, Sandhu also recalled his student days, saying he used to frequent Kamla Nagar, also known to him as Knags. He said he had visited the market to buy a belt and sample local food but ended up interacting with residents who shared both appreciation and complaints.

He said his effort was to directly engage with people, understand their concerns and do his best to resolve them.

MCD extends property tax amnesty scheme till April 30

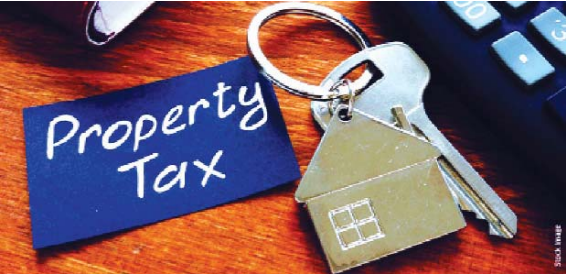
PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) has extended its property tax amnesty scheme, SUNIYO, till April 30, 2026, offering taxpayers another opportunity to clear pending dues without penalties or interest, Mayor Sardar Raja Iqbal Singh announced on Tuesday.

The extension comes in view of the positive response from citizens, officials said, with the civic body urging all eligible property owners to take advantage of the scheme before the final deadline.

"In light of the encouraging response from citizens, the property tax amnesty scheme has been extended till April 30, 2026. We appeal to all property owners to make full use of this opportunity," the Mayor said. He added that the scheme will not be extended further beyond this date.

Under the scheme, taxpayers can avail a complete waiver of property tax dues prior to the financial year 2020-21. However, this benefit is conditional upon payment of the principal tax amount for the current financial year 2025-26 and the previous five years, from 2020-21 to 2024-25, without any interest or



penalty. Officials said the scheme is aimed at encouraging voluntary compliance and reducing the burden of accumulated dues on taxpayers.

The Mayor said citizens have been actively participating in the scheme and clearing their liabilities. He noted that the late fee has not been increased and remains at 5 per cent, the same rate that was applicable during the previous extension period from February 1 to March 31, 2026.

"We have kept the late fee unchanged to ensure that more people can benefit from the scheme and settle their dues," he said.

The SUNIYO scheme is designed to provide relief to property owners who have pending tax liabilities, allowing them to regularise their records without facing additional financial penalties. Civic officials said the initiative is also expected to improve revenue collection for the municipal cor-

poration while easing the financial burden on residents.

The MCD has urged defaulters and non-filers to take advantage of the scheme and clear all outstanding dues within the extended deadline.

Officials warned that strict action will be initiated against those who fail to comply after the scheme period ends. "After April 30, coercive measures will be taken against defaulters who do not clear their dues," an official said.

The civic body said the extension provides a final opportunity for taxpayers to resolve pending issues without legal or financial consequences.

The scheme applies to all eligible property taxpayers across Delhi and covers a significant backlog of unpaid taxes. Officials said efforts are being made to raise awareness about the scheme to ensure maximum participation.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police's Anti-Narcotics Squad (East District) has busted an international drug syndicate, arresting four persons in connection with the case. According to officials, police also recovered a large quantity of psychotropic substances worth about ₹1.1 crore in the illegal market, making this a significant seizure announced on Tuesday.

The accused include two alleged drug peddlers as well as two foreign nationals, who were identified as sources of supply. In addition, police seized two scooty used for transportation, one of which bore a fake number plate and was later found to be stolen. "The campaign against substance abuse is being carried out continuously to eradicate the drug menace," said Deputy Commissioner of Police (East) Rajeev Kumar. He also added that all efforts are being made to ensure a drug-free society, highlighting the significance of this operation as a major breakthrough in that effort.

Police said a total of 120.18 grams of cocaine and 36.86 grams of MDMA, both classified as commercial quantities, were recovered during the operation. The case began on March 25 when the Anti-Narcotics Squad received



specific information about a man identified as Mohd Hasan, who was allegedly supplying MDMA near Chitra Vihar Jhuggi and Kohinoor Hotel in Preet Vihar.

A trap was laid, and Hasan, a 23-year-old resident of Geeta Colony, was apprehended while riding a scooty. Police recovered 7.58 grams of MDMA from his possession. A case under the NDPS Act was registered at the Preet Vihar police station.

During interrogation, Hasan revealed that he sourced the drugs from an African national known as "Oscar," who operated in areas near Outer Ring Road and Srinivasapuri.

Acting on this lead, police teams conducted a late-night operation on March 27-28 and arrested Diouf Solomon, also known as Oscar, a 27-year-old resident of Senegal, near Srinivasapuri. He was

found carrying 4.43 grams of MDMA and was using a scooty with a fake number plate.

Verification revealed that the scooty had been stolen from Uttam Nagar in 2025. It was seized along with the contraband. Further investigation and technical surveillance led the police to a residence in Amrit Puri, where another accused, Bemah, a 30-year-old resident of Liberia, was arrested.

A search of the premises led to the recovery of 120.18 grams of cocaine and 15.71 grams of MDMA. Police also seized a weighing machine, packaging materials, an electronic sealing machine, six mobile phones, two passports, and cash.

In a subsequent operation on March 29, police arrested a fourth accused, Razia, from Mandawali. She was identified as a receiver and local distributor.

GOVERNMENT OF MANIPUR
PUBLIC WORKS DEPARTMENT

NOTICE INVITING TENDERS

Dt. Imphal, the 30th March, 2026.

No.EE/BD-II/Man-Ten/2025-26/10: The Executive Engineer, Building Division No.II, P.W.D., Manipur on behalf of the Governor of Manipur invites item rate Tender through manual Tender from eligible registered contractors of PWD, Manipur for the work "Construction of Top floor over existing RCC roof, i/c renovation of 2" & 3" floor of Manipur Press Club Building at Majorkhul, Imphal" under MH:2059-PW(P) at an Estimated Cost less than 1 (one) crore.

The procurement officer is the Executive Engineer, Building Division No. II, PWD, Manipur. The details and documents shall be available from 11:00 hrs. of 30/03/2026 to 14:00 hrs. of 08/04/2026 at the office of the Executive Engineer, Building Division No. II, PWD, Manipur.

Bid Submission start date: **30/03/2026 (11:00 AM)** Bid Submission end date: **08/04/2026 (2:00PM)**

Date of opening Bid: **08/04/2026 at 3:00PM.** Venue :- Office of the EE, B.D-II, PWD, Manipur.

Sd/-
Executive Engineer
B.D-II/P.W.D, Manipur

NORTHERN RAILWAY
OPEN-E-TENDER NOTICE

The Sr. Divisional Engineer-III, Northern Railway, Delhi Division invites E-Tender for the following work.

1	Name of work	Rag picking along track in the section of SSE/P.Way/NDLS under ADEN/NDLS.
2	Approx cost of work	Rs. 81,99,395.20/- (Rupees Eighty One Lakh Ninety Nine Thousand Three Hundred Ninety Five and Twenty Paise Only)
3	Earnest Money to be deposited	Rs. 1,64,000.00/- (Rupees One Lakh Sixty Four Thousand Only)
4	Cost of tender document	Rs. 0.00/-
5	Date & Time of submission of tender bid and opening of tender	22.04.2026 at 15:00 Hrs.
6	Website particulars where complete details of tender documents can be seen	www.ireps.gov.in
7	Allocation	04-210-32

• The tenderer/s must be registered on the Indian Railway E-Procurement system (IREPS) site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for participating in the e-tender system. • For all terms and conditions please refer tender document. • No manual offers are acceptable. • Cost of tender document and Earnest money will be acceptable through net banking or payment gateway only. No. 128-W/280/e Tender Notice/NIT/59/2025-26/W-3 Dated :- 30.03.2026 1080/2026

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CHANGE OF NAME

I, Hitherto known as Adesh Kumar Sharma alias Adesh Kumar S/o Ram Chander Sharma R/o RZ-46/165, G.N. 7, Durga Park, Palam Village S.O., Dist: South West Delhi, Delhi-110045 have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Adesh Kumar.

PD(714)C
I, No.15681989H Hav Jitendra Kumar Narwle, R/o- 514A Ramkrishna Bag Colony, Robot Square, PO- Vijay Nagar Indore PS- Khajrana, M.P- 452010 declare that in my service record, my father's name & DOB has been wrongly recorded as Shankar Lal Narwle 01/07/1960 whereas his correct name & DOB is Shankar Lal Narwale 25/11/1959 which may be amended accordingly.

PD(715)C
I, No.4290590L Nk Gadigeppa Hallad, R/o- Vill- Inamahongal, Tel- Saundatti, Dist- Belagavi, Karnataka-591126, have changed my Daughter's name from Kirti Hallad to Kirti Gadigeppa Hallad, vide affidavit dated 31/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(716)C

PD(717)C
I, No.4290590L Nk Gadigeppa Hallad, R/o- Vill- Inamahongal, Tel- Saundatti, Dist- Belagavi, Karnataka- 591126, have changed my Son's name from Vijaykumar to Vijaykumar Gadigeppa Hallad, vide affidavit dated 31/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(718)C
I, Sarojini Hallad, W/o- No.4290590L Nk Gadigeppa Hallad, R/o- Vill- Inamahongal Parassgad, Dist- Belgaum, Karnataka- 591126, have changed my name from Sarojini Hallad to Sarojini Gadigeppa Hallad, vide affidavit dated 31/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(719)C

PUBLIC NOTICE

Mr. Rahul Sharma & Mrs. Toyash Vishishtha have approached ICICI Bank Ltd., Sector-50, Gurgaon, U.P. (Bank) to avail a Loan against mortgage of Flat No. 175, Ground Floor, SFS Category-III, Sidhartha Enclave, New Delhi-110014, (after release of the same from Tata Capital Housing Finance Ltd) where it is already mortgaged and have also represented that they are the absolute owners of the said property by virtue of Sale Deed dated 05.12.2024 (Document No. 2024/9/7723 dated 07.12.2024) executed by Mr. Tahir Hasan. If anybody, person, body corporate other than Tata Capital Housing Finance Ltd, has any right, lien, claim or objections whatsoever on the said Property by way of inheritance, mortgage, sale or otherwise, then he/she/it may contact the undersigned with documentary proof of claim within 15 days of publication of this notice. If no claim or objection shall be entertained thereafter and Bank shall proceed to advance the loan on mortgaging of the said property.

Amit Kumar, Advocate
Narang & Associates
D-28, Jangpura Extension,
New Delhi-110014.

PD(717)C

PUBLIC NOTICE

To, Mr. Birender Kumar s/o Sh. Mahabir Singh R/o Village Kanina, Tehsil Kanina, District Mahendragar, Haryana (Address available as per record): 9813778990, 9050273452

This is to inform you that physical possession of Flat No. 401, Tower-2, Vipul Garden, Dharuhera was handed over to our clients (Ms. Raj Rani Malkoti, Kamal Vetrar) nominee Ms. Anupama on 29.03.2026 by you/your nominee. However, you have failed to remove your belongings and household items from the said premises till date. It has further come to our clients' knowledge that maintenance dues of the society for more than 4 years, amounting to approximately ₹2,50,000/- along with rent for 3 months, remain unpaid and were not disclosed by you at the time of handing over possession.

You are hereby called upon to remove all your belongings and household items from the above premises within 7 days or on or before 07.04.2026, after obtaining prior written permission from our clients, failing which our clients shall be constraining to approximately ₹2,50,000/- of objection/negligence, Charge etc., kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 07 days of the present.

Kumar & Associates (Advocates & Consultants)
200, Indir Nagar, New Delhi-110015
T: 911112527-28

Valourium Legal Solutions LLP
(Advocate), Cabin No. 11,
E-25/1, Hauz Khas Main Market,
New Delhi-110016. Mob: 9810194951

CHITTARANJAN LOCOMOTIVE WORKS

WALK-IN-INTERVIEW
FOR CONTRACTUAL TEACHERS

Walk-in-Interview will be conducted for engagement of Part-Time Contractual Teachers (PGT/TGT/Physical Instructor) in Railway Schools [D.V. Girls', D.V. Boys' & CHS (EM)], Chittaranjan for the academic session 2026-27.

KEY DETAILS:
Engagement: Purely contractual (up to 200 working days).
Remuneration (consolidated): PGT: ₹27,500/- per month, TGT: ₹26,250/- per month. **Age Limit:** 18-65 years (as on date of notification). **Qualification:** As per Railway Board norms.

INTERVIEW DETAILS:
Venue: Hindi Library, GM Office Building, CLW/Chittaranjan, Dist. Paschim Bardhaman, West Bengal. **Reporting Time:** 09:30 Hrs to 13:30 Hrs.

IMPORTANT INSTRUCTIONS:
Candidates must bring original certificates along with self-attested copies, No TA/DA will be admissible, Engagement is purely temporary and will not confer any right for regular appointment.

FOR DETAILED NOTIFICATION, visit: www.cwclw.in railways.gov.in under link **News & Recruitment** → **Recruitment** → (A 'Walk-In Interview' for engagement of Teacher for the post of PGT, TGT and Physical instructor in Railway School/CLW/Chittaranjan purely on Contract Basis for the academic session 2026-27 scheduled from 09.04.2026) → **Download**.

PR8/320 Personnel Officer (B&S)/CLW/Chittaranjan
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HINDUSTAN AUTO FINANCE LIMITED

CIN: L65910DL1980PLC010617

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Phone: +91 9027214958

Email: hindaf1980@gmail.com; Website: www.hindaf.in

NOTICE

Pursuant to SEBI Circular dated 30.01.2026, shareholders are informed that to facilitate ease of investment and safeguard investor rights, a special window has been introduced for transfer and dematerialisation of physical securities.

A special window is now open for securities bought/sold prior to April 1, 2019.

The window will remain open from April 01, 2026 to February 4, 2027.

It also covers cases where earlier transfer requests were rejected, returned, or pending due to incomplete documentation or procedural issues.

All approved securities will be credited only in demat form to the transferee. For details, visit Company website or contact RTA.

For Hindustan Auto Finance Limited

Auth. Signatory
Date: 31.03.2026

Delhi records its wettest, hottest, polluted March in recent years

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Rain on one day, heat on another, and pollution remaining elevated throughout, the weather this month was anything but business as usual, as Delhi recorded its most polluted March in four years, its wettest in three years and its hottest since 2022.

An analysis by the CREA (Centre for Research on Energy and Clean Air) showed that the Capital recorded its most polluted March in four years in 2026, with an average Air Quality Index (AQI) reading of 181 till March 30, the highest since 2022, when it stood at 217. In comparison,

the average AQI reading was 170 in 2023, 176 in 2024 and 170 in 2025. In March 2026, Delhi recorded one 'satisfactory' day, 22 'moderate' days and eight 'poor' days, the analysis showed.

A breakdown of AQI categories shows that in March 2022, Delhi recorded 12 'moderate' days and 19 'poor' days. In 2023, there were three 'satisfactory' days, 20 'moderate' days and eight 'poor' days. In 2024, the city saw 26 'moderate' days and five 'poor' days. In 2025, there were two 'satisfactory' days, 20 'moderate' days and nine 'poor' days.

According to the CREA analysis based on data from the Central Pollution Control

Board, the AQI reading of 266 recorded on March 10 was the highest for the month of March since 2023.

On the weather front, the month was among the hottest in recent years. The average maximum temperature stood at 32.6 degrees Celsius, making it the highest in four years. The last time the average maximum temperature was higher in March was in 2022, when it reached 33.4 degrees Celsius.

The average minimum temperature for March 2026 stood at 17.6 degrees Celsius, the highest in four years since 2022, when it was at the same level.

This was also the wettest March in the last three years.



Rainfall in March 2026 was recorded at 19.82 mm, making it the highest for the month since 2023, when rainfall was significantly higher at 50.4 mm, while rainfall in 2024 and 2025 remained

lower than 2026 levels.

The India Meteorological Department said six western disturbances affected north-west India between March 11 and 31, leading to thunderstorms and rainfall activity.

Experts also noted a shift in the nature of pollution this month, with gaseous pollutants playing a more prominent role. "Ozone emerged as the prominent pollutant for 16 days during the month. There were also higher concentrations of gaseous pollutants such as ozone, carbon monoxide and nitrogen dioxide compared to March in previous years," they said.

Highlighting the trend, Manoj Kumar, analyst at the CREA, said, "March highlights the growing importance of addressing gaseous pollutants like ozone, carbon monoxide, sulphur dioxide and nitrogen dioxide alongside particulate matter. To effectively tackle Delhi's year-

round air pollution, policy focus must expand to include both particulate and gaseous pollution targets."

Explaining why temperatures remained relatively high despite rainfall, Mahesh Palawat of Skymet Weather said the showers largely occurred in the late afternoon, after the day's maximum temperature had already been recorded. "If the rain had taken place earlier in the day, it would have had a greater impact on temperatures," he said.

He added that the rainfall was scattered, on and off, and not widespread. "The reason the temperatures were not significantly affected is that the showers were brief and

passing in nature," he said.

Explaining the impact of meteorological conditions on pollution trends, Palawat said that the winds blowing from the west and southwest brought dust from the Thar desert to Delhi. He added that moderate wind speeds, along with dry and hot conditions in the initial days of the month, contributed to elevated pollution levels.

"Similar conditions are likely to continue, with light rain expected in patches between April 2 and 4. Thunderstorms are likely between April 6 and 8, which may prevent heatwave conditions in the early part of the month," he said.

NCR witnesses sudden weather turn

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Cloudy skies and spells of rain greeted Delhi residents on Tuesday as the National Capital Region (NCR) witnessed a sudden weather shift that afternoon — dark clouds covering the skyline, followed by strong winds that brought down visibility and created near-evening conditions during the day.

The India Meteorological Department has issued a yellow alert, indicating "be updated", with a generally cloudy sky and intermittent very light to light rain accompanied by thunderstorms, lightning and strong surface winds of 20-30 km/h, gusting up to 40 km/h during the evening and night.

The India Meteorological Department also shared an update on X, warning that under the influence of two active western disturbances, a wet spell is set to continue across northwest India this week, with peak activity expected on April 3 and 4. The abrupt weather change



Girls shielding themselves from light rain near Kartavya Path in New Delhi

PANKAJ KUMAR

follows several days of fluctuating conditions across Delhi and neighbouring states, where intermittent showers have kept temperatures relatively pleasant despite brief spells of heat.

The main cause of these changing weather conditions is an active western disturbance, which is an extratropical weather phenomenon

originating over the Mediterranean and moving eastward towards India.

Rainfall recorded between 2.30 pm and 5.30 pm stood at 2.1 mm at Safdarjung, 2.6 mm at Palam, 2.8 mm at Lodi Road, 2.4 mm at Ridge and 2.2 mm at Ayanagar.

Among other stations, Janakpuri recorded the highest rainfall at 4 mm,

while Pusa and Mayur Vihar received 2 mm each and Pitampura recorded 1.5 mm.

Maximum temperatures across stations remained in a similar range above normal, with Safdarjung recording 33.7 degrees Celsius, Palam 33.2 degrees, Lodi Road 33.2 degrees, Ridge 33.9 degrees and Ayanagar 33.8 degrees.

Security tightened ahead of Hanuman Jayanti

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Police has intensified security arrangements in northwest Delhi ahead of Hanuman Jayanti, with senior officers conducting flag marches and an Aman committee meeting held in Jahangirpuri to ensure communal harmony, an officer said on Tuesday.

A multi-layered security plan has been implemented across the district for the festival on April 2, with special focus on sensitive areas such as Jahangirpuri in view of the 2022 violence.

Senior officers are closely monitoring the situation on the ground, while additional police personnel and paramilitary forces, including a company of the Rapid Action Force (RAF), have been deployed in vulnerable pockets.

Police said they have also intensified bike and foot patrolling in sensitive areas, markets, temples and procession routes to ensure safety and law and order.



"An Aman committee meeting was convened at the Jahangirpuri police station. DCP (Northwest) Akanksha Yadav, Additional DCP Sikandar Singh and ACP (Shalimar Bagh) Rohit Gupta were present during the meeting," a senior police officer said.

The meeting was aimed at strengthening coordination with residents and ensuring peaceful conduct of festivities. Discussions were held on security arrangements, crowd management and strict adherence to guide-

lines during the procession, according to the officer.

Police said all processions will follow designated routes and fixed timings under close supervision. Adequate deployment and senior officers on the ground will ensure continuous monitoring. Authorities have capped participation at 500 people per procession and imposed restrictions, including a ban on carrying weapons, lathis or any hazardous object. Provocative slogans or speeches that may disturb communal harmony have

A MULTI-LAYERED SECURITY PLAN HAS BEEN IMPLEMENTED ACROSS NORTHWEST DISTRICT FOR THE FESTIVAL ON APRIL 2

also been prohibited.

"Surveillance has been enhanced through CCTV cameras, drones and local intelligence inputs.

Barricades have been placed at key points, and area domination exercises and flag marches are being carried out to instil confidence among residents," the officer said. A comprehensive traffic diversion plan has also been put in place to ensure smooth vehicular movement.

Police said the elaborate arrangements are aimed at preventing any untoward incident in view of the 2022 violence in Jahangirpuri, when eight police personnel and a local were injured in stone-pelting and arson incidents during a Hanuman Jayanti procession, with several vehicles torched.



Narendra Modi
Prime Minister



Delhi Tourism



Government of the National Capital Territory of Delhi



DEPARTMENT OF
Art
Culture
& Languages
DELHI GOVERNMENT



Rekha Gupta
Chief Minister

Indraprastha Cultural Festival

3rd-5th APRIL 2026



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IN FOCUS



LGBTQIA+ community supporters stage a protest against the passage of the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Bill, 2026 on International Transgender Day of Visibility, in Dehradun, Uttarakhand on Tuesday

PTI

Assam polls about chasing out infiltrators, says Irani

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Dhemaji (Assam)

Former Union minister Smriti Irani on Tuesday asserted that the Assam assembly elections this time were about “chasing out each and every infiltrator” from the country, while accusing the Congress of shielding the illegal migrants and covering the state under “dark clouds” of militancy. She maintained that the BJP-led government has ensured progress for the state on all fronts, with women especially leading the development narrative now.

Addressing a campaign rally for the party’s Sissiborgaon constituency candidate Jibon Gogoi, Irani said, “This election is not about making someone an MLA or Himanta Biswa Sarma the chief minister again. This is about chasing out each and every infiltrator away from our country.”

Mentioning the Dhemaji blast of August 15, 2004, in which 13 people, including school children, were killed, the BJP leader said, “These were innocent people killed. What was their mistake? Such dark clouds engulfed the state that innocents lost their lives.” Irani asserted that the state has now reached a phase where everyone can unfurl the National Flag without any fear, which was a credit of the current dispensation at the



Centre and the state. Accusing the Congress of shielding the infiltrators, she questioned why the grand old party and its allies in the Opposition were against the revision of electoral rolls before the elections.

“Only Indians should be included in the electoral rolls. When the Election Commission wanted to revise the rolls, why did the Congress protest it? They want to protect Indians or the infiltrators?” she questioned.

Irani lauded the state government for clearing over 1.65 lakh bighas of land from illegal encroachers, while hitting out at the Congress for failing to take any step while in power. Maintaining that the state has been marching in the path of development in the last 10 years, the former MP and popular actor said women are occupying a central position in this growth narrative.

West Asia crisis: India to receive Iranian crude oil shipment

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Amid the Israel-US conflict with Iran and the chokehold on the Hormuz Strait in the Persian Gulf, India’s first cargo of Iranian crude oil since 2019 is set to head towards a port in Gujarat.

The move comes in the backdrop of surging crude prices due to the West Asian crisis; Indian refiners have been seeking to ramp up procurement of a few cargoes of Iranian oil on water following the recent sanctions waiver by Washington.

“The Indo-Iranian oil trade has flickered back to life. Following the US administration’s decision to grant a 30-day window for Iranian oil ‘on the water’ due to regional conflict, the vessel Ping Shun is now en route to Vadinar (in Gujarat) with 600,000 barrels of crude. This is the first such delivery since May 2019 and comes at a critical time for Indian refiners facing tightening inventories,” said Sumit Ritolia, Lead Research Analyst, Refining and



Modelling at commodity market analytic firm Kpler. “The Aframax Ping Shun (IMO 9231901) loaded with Iranian crude oil from Kharg Island in early March has emerged as the first vessel observed signalling a destination of Vadinar, India since May 2019, following sanction reimposition on Iranian oil by the first Trump administration,” Ritolia said.

While the identity of the buyer could not be ascertained, Vadinar is home to a 20 million-tonne-a-year oil refinery of Russian oil giant Rosneft-backed Nayara Energy. It is also the landing point for crude oil that goes to the Bina refinery of Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL). The petroleum min-

istry has so far maintained that techno-commercial feasibility will drive the decision on resuming Iranian crude supplies. Historically, India was a major buyer of Iranian crude, importing significant volumes of Iranian light and heavy grades due to strong refinery compatibility and favourable commercial terms. However, after sanctions in 2018, imports ceased from May 2019, with volumes replaced by Middle Eastern, US and other grades.

Iranian crude accounted for 11.5 per cent of India’s total imports before the sanctions regime.

India used to buy 518,000 barrels per day of Iranian oil in 2018, which slowed to 268,000 bpd between

January and May 2019 when the US granted waivers to a few buyers. Subsequently, imports came to a naught. Back in 2009-10, India imported 22.1 million tonnes of Iranian crude, and it accounted for 14.4% of India’s overall oil imports, according to data from the Ministry of Commerce and Industry.

Last month, the US waived sanctions on the purchase of Iranian oil at sea for 30 days in its bid to ease oil prices that have spiralled up following the US-Israeli war on Iran. That waiver expires on April 19. An estimated 95 million barrels of Iranian oil are on vessels at sea, of which around 51 million barrels could be sold to India, while the remaining are compatible for buyers in China and Southeast Asia.

“The tanker is estimated to have loaded approximately 600 kb (600,000 barrels) from Kharg Island around 4 March, with a declared ETA to Vadinar on 4 April,” Ritolia added. While the US waiver allowed countries to purchase those barrels, the mode of payment remains unclear.

Navy key to security: Vice Admiral Sobti

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Panaji

Deputy Chief of Naval Staff Vice Admiral Tarun Sobti on Tuesday said the recent global developments reaffirm the need for a strong navy and with rising strategic competitions and conflicts, the Indian Navy remains the prime manifestation of the country’s maritime power.

He was addressing a gathering during the launch of the first NGOPVbuilt by Goa Shipyard Limited in Vasco. “India’s identity as a maritime nation is defined by its geography and history.

With a vast coastline, numerous land territories, both in the Arabian Sea and Bay of Bengal, and an Exclusive Economic Zone, our maritime domain is both a source of responsibility and of opportunities,” Vice Admiral Sobti said.

Chhattisgarh now free of Naxalism: CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Raipur

Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai on Tuesday asserted Chhattisgarh was now “free” of Naxalism and described March 31, the deadline set by the Centre to eradicate Maoism, as a “historic” day for the state, which was once a hotbed of the violent movement. Targeting the Opposition Congress, Sai alleged that during the ‘Bharat Jodo Yatra’, party leader Rahul Gandhi had shared the stage with Naxalites at several locations.

Speaking on the sidelines of a programme in Raipur, the CM thanked Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah for providing decisive leadership in the fight against Left-wing extremism (LWE) and said the insurgency had long been a major obstacle to development.

“Today marks a truly historic day for Chhattisgarh as Naxalism is being eliminat-



ed from the State. On behalf of the 30 million people of Chhattisgarh, we extend our deepest gratitude to Prime Minister Modi ji and Home Minister Amit Shah ji,” he said. In 2024, the Centre set a deadline of March 31, 2026, to completely eliminate Naxal violence from the country. The vast Bastar region, once an epicentre of Naxal violence, remained largely untouched by development for 40 years, but it can now progress rapidly, Sai maintained.

Asked about Shah’s statement in the Lok Sabha on Monday that when Rahul Gandhi undertook his

march, many Leftists joined it, Sai said, “During the ‘Desh Jodo Yatra’ undertaken by the Congress MP, he met Naxalites at numerous locations. At several places, Naxalites even shared the stage with him (Gandhi), the BJP leader alleged.

“When notorious Naxal leader Madvi Hidma, responsible for killing hundreds of people, including our security personnel, was neutralised (in late 2025), people chanted slogans that ‘many more Hidmas will emerge’. Gandhi even posted those (slogans) on social media, which shows his intent,” the CM stated.

When pointed out that former CM Bhupesh Baghel used to claim that evidence regarding the deadly Jhiram Ghati attack by Maoists was in his “pocket”, Sai said, “When the Congress was in power, it failed to act despite claiming to have enough proof.” Even after being in power for five years (2018-23), they could neither investigate the Jhiram Ghati case nor

India must be ready for world, world for India, says Jaishankar



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Raigir (Bihar)

The world is becoming “more multi-polar” because there are many more cultures and societies that are making their voices heard, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar said on Tuesday, asserting that the Nalanda tradition can be a powerful influence in this “democratisation” of the global order.

In his address at the second convocation ceremony of Nalanda University in Bihar’s Raigir, he also said, as the country advances towards a Viksit Bharat, “it is essential that India is ready for the world and equally, the world for India”.

The university, which aims to revive the ancient glory of the historic Nalanda as an international institution for

the pursuit of intellectual, philosophical, historical, and spiritual studies, was conceived as a collaboration between India and East Asia Summit (EAS) countries.

The historic Nalanda University, whose famed archaeological ruins is a UNESCO World Heritage Site, is located in today’s Nalanda district of Bihar.

The campus of the new university, bearing the name of the ancient seat of learning, was inaugurated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on June 19, 2024.

Jaishankar said each such milestone marks an evolution of an emerging institution and is a cause for celebration in itself, and “It has been my personal good fortune to be associated with this university from the very start”.

AMARAVATI TO BE SOLE CAPITAL OF AP: BILL TO BE INTRODUCED IN LS

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Government is likely to introduce a bill in the Lok Sabha on Wednesday to recognise Amravati as the sole and permanent capital of Andhra Pradesh, fulfilling a vital aspiration of key NDA ally TDP and Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu.

The legislation will scuttle any future bid to alter the decision of making Amravati the sole and permanent capital..

Corrigendum

In a news report titled ‘CAG slams MEA..’ on page 4 of the edition dated March 31, 2026, a photo of Consul General of India at Shanghai, Pratik Mathur, was mistakenly carried. We deeply regret the error.

-Executive Editor

Congress spreading panic amidst crisis, says PM...

Addressing a gathering on the occasion, Modi said India is actively building a robust semiconductor ecosystem and simultaneously making significant efforts to establish a resilient supply chain for raw materials.

Modi noted that when the Coronavirus pandemic disrupted supply chains, India had decided to become a hub of semiconductor manufacturing. “India is actively building a robust semiconductor ecosystem and simultaneously making significant efforts to establish a resilient supply chain for raw materials. India’s participation in Pax Silica is a testament to this very endeavour. Working in tandem with our global partners, we aim to ensure a secure supply chain,” Modi added. India recently joined Pax Silica, a US-led strategic coalition launched in December 2025 to secure critical technology supply chains, with a special focus on semiconductors, AI, and rare earth elements.

“Furthermore, to achieve self-reliance in critical minerals, India has launched the National Critical Minerals Mission,” Modi said, adding that this mission emphasises mining and production of critical minerals. Modi said that in 2021, India launched the India Semiconductor Mission, which is not just an industrial policy but a declaration of India’s confidence.

The PM also inaugurated and laid foundation stones for development projects totalling Rs 19,806.9 crore, including ₹10,921 crore under Union ministries and Rs 8,886 crore under Gujarat government departments.

Eight dead in Bihar temple stampede

“The mishap in Nalanda district, Bihar, is deeply painful. I extend my condolences to those who have lost their loved ones. Prayers for the speedy recovery of those injured,” the PM said in a message.

Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar expressed grief over the deaths of devotees in the stampede and announced ex gratia for the kin of the deceased. “The CM has expressed condolences over the casualties in the stampede at the Sheela Mata temple in Bihar Sharif. He is deeply saddened by the deaths of devotees in the incident, and announced an ex gratia of ₹6 lakh each to the immediate family members of the deceased.

The CM has also directed officials to ensure better treatment for those who are injured,” a statement issued by the Chief Minister’s Office (CMO) said. Bihar Deputy Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary in a social media post said, “The incident at Sheela Mata Temple in Nalanda is extremely heartbreaking. I express my condolences to the families of all the devotees who lost their lives and were injured in this accident. The government is providing every possible assistance and relief to the affected families.”

“Arrangements have been made for the proper treatment of the injured. May God grant peace to the departed souls and provide strength to the grieving families during this hour of sorrow. I pray for the swift recovery of the injured,” he said.

Leader of Opposition in the Bihar Assembly, Tejashwi Yadav, accused the government of alleged “administrative mismanagement” for the incident. He said, “The incident caused by administrative mismanagement, resulting in the deaths of devotees, is deeply saddening. I pray to God for the peace of the departed souls and for the speedy recovery of the injured. My heartfelt condolences are with the bereaved families.”

Top JeM ultra dies mysteriously, senior...

No details about illness, accident or any preceding incident were mentioned in the announcement. Funeral prayers were held late on Monday night at Jamia Masjid Usman Wali also called Jamia Masjid Usman-o-Ali, a mosque linked to JeM in Bahawalpur. The city in Pakistan’s Punjab province is the group’s known stronghold and houses JeM’s headquarters at Jamia Masjid Subhan Allah. According to sources in the security agencies, the funeral saw a rare gathering of top leadership, including Masood Azhar. Ibrahim Azhar, Talha al Saif, Abdur Rauf and Mohammad Ammar Alvi.

There is silence in Pakistani media on Anwar’s death, ostensibly on the orders of the GHQ Rawalpindi which does not want people to know the reasons of Anwar’s sudden demise. Pakistani officials have also not issued any public statement on the matter either.

In 2025, Azhar publicly claimed that 10 family members and aides were killed in Indian airstrikes under Operation Sindoor following the Pahalgam terror attack. Those deaths were acknowledged indirectly by JeM commanders

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but Masood Azhar has not spoken about the circumstances leading to his elder brother Anwar’s death. No group has claimed responsibility, and there is no public evidence of foul play at this stage. Anwar was one of Masood Azhar’s five brothers and a long-standing senior operative within Jaish-e-Mohammed. He had been actively involved in the outfit’s operations for several years and was considered a key figure in its terror network. He was also involved in scores of terrorist attacks on Indian security forces in Jammu and Kashmir. According to Indian security agencies, Anwar was a central figure for over two decades, overseeing terrorist training operations, weapons procurement and supply chains for Jaish cadres since 2001. Indian agencies, citing JeM channels and intelligence inputs, consistently describe the circumstances of Anwar’s death as mysterious, unclear or suspicious.

JeM, founded by Masood Azhar in 2000 after his release in the IC-814 hijacking, has been designated a terrorist organisation by India, the UN, the US, the UK and other countries. It has been linked to major attacks in India, including the 2001 Parliament attack, 2016 Pathankot, Uri, and 2019 Pulwama terrorist attacks. There are many conspiracy theories floating including that a few days ago, an unidentified woman allegedly pricked him with a pin on his back while he was returning from Namaz. A few variations claim that Anwar was shot by unknown gunmen.

It may be noted that since May 2025, Masood Azhar has lost 11 close family members, a major blow to the organization, which relies heavily on relatives to maintain secrecy around its terror attacks.

MCD officials caught red-handed by CBI...

The CBI acted swiftly after receiving specific inputs about the bribe demand. No further details about the complainant, the exact nature of the “official work,” or any other linked persons have been released yet, as the investigation is ongoing. Officials have described it as a standard anti-corruption operation. This case highlights continued CBI scrutiny of civic bodies in Delhi, especially the MCD, where bribery complaints related to licenses, approvals, and municipal work are not uncommon. A similar MCD assistant engineer case was reported earlier this month.

As of now, both officers remain in custody. The CBI sleuths are investigating the past actions of

the accused duo to ascertain whether there were instances of quid pro quo and cases were settled by taking bribes.

Go get your own oil: Trump tells allies as...

Responding to the rising tensions, Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi maintained that Tehran’s actions are defensive in nature and directed solely at US forces in the region. “Our operations are aimed at enemy aggressors who have no respect for Arabs or Iranians, nor can provide any security,” he said in a statement posted on X. As the situation in the Gulf remains volatile, Trump’s remarks are likely to deepen strains within traditional alliances while raising fresh concerns about global energy security and the future direction of US foreign policy commitments.

Special session aims to pass women’s quota...

The decision to hold the Bill in the Budget session was proposed in the Business Advisory Committee (BAC) of the Lok Sabha when the Union Government indicated that a special session of Parliament may be convened if required.

Congress-led Opposition members sought an all-party meeting on proposed amendments to the Women’s Reservation Act. Signed by key members like the Congress, SP, DMK, RJD and Left parties, they called for wider consultations. However, Trinamool Congress is not a signatory. The proposed framework includes structural changes to ease implementation. The Government is considering a 50 per cent proportionate increase in Lok Sabha seats, ensuring that no State loses its existing representation. If cleared, it would push the number of seats in the Lok Sabha up by 50 per cent, from the existing 543 to 816, with the 273-seat increase earmarked for women.

Reserved constituencies for women may be fixed for three consecutive terms, after which rotation will be introduced. Within seats reserved for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes, a 33 per cent quota for women is proposed.

Seat allocation within States is likely to be based on data of 2011 Census. Sources said by using the 2011 Census as a baseline, the Government hopes to roll out one-third reser-

vation for women in time for the next General Election and subsequent Assembly polls.

The Bill will require a two-thirds majority in Parliament. The treasury benches are in discussion with Congress and other Opposition parties, which overwhelmingly supported the passage in the 2023 Special Session, which happened on the occasion of shifting to the new Parliament Building.

Govt affects major bureaucratic overhaul

Gyanendra D Tripathi, a 1998 batch IAS officer of Assam-Meghalaya cadre, has been appointed as additional secretary, Department of Agricultural Research and Education and Secretary, Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR).

Sridhar Chiruvolu, joint secretary in the Prime Minister’s Office (PMO), has been appointed as additional secretary at the same place. Ansuman Pattanaik, director general, Competition Commission of India, will be additional secretary, Ministry of Corporate Affairs, the order said.

N Gulzar, additional secretary in the Department of Telecommunications, has been appointed as member secretary, National Capital Region Planning Board, while Diwakar Nath Misra will be additional secretary, Ministry of Power and Debasish Prusty will be the new additional secretary, Department of Financial Services.

Arti Kanwar has been appointed as additional secretary, Ministry of Textiles, Darpan Jain as additional secretary, Department of Commerce, and Ankita Mishra Bundela as additional secretary, Department of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare. While Lokhande Prashant Sitaram and Anuj Sharma have been appointed as additional secretaries in the Home Affairs Ministry, Gujarat-cadre IAS officer Vijay Nehra has been appointed as additional secretary, Department of Health and Family Welfare, Siddharth Jain as additional secretary, Ministry of Cooperation, and Neetu Kumari Prasad as additional secretary, Department of Revenue, the order said. Meenaxi Rawat will be additional secretary and financial adviser, Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change; Yashvir Singh will be additional secretary, Department of Commerce, and Hari Har Mishra will be additional secretary, Department of Financial Services.

Veena Kumari Dermal has been named additional secretary in the Mines Ministry while Aparna Bhatia will be Additional Secretary and Financial Adviser, Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food & Public Distribution.

Social media scraping is safe: MHA

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) has told a parliamentary panel that security agencies rely exclusively on open-source intelligence (OSINT) drawn from publicly available information on the internet and social media platforms, stressing that no private or personal data is collected and therefore no privacy is violated.

The MHA's detailed submission was made to the Standing Committee on Communications and Information Technology (2024-25), chaired by Lok Sabha member Nishikant Dubey. The committee tabled its report in Parliament on Monday after seeking clarifications on how the Union Government handles privacy concerns while scraping the internet and social media for intelligence purposes.

"Publicly available information on the internet and social media platforms is used for intelligence gathering. No private or personal information is gathered from

social media. Hence, privacy is never violated," the ministry stated in its written reply to the panel. 'Scraping', the MHA explained, involves the use of specialised computer programmes and tools that automatically browse only public web pages and social media posts, the MHA submitted before the parliamentary committee.

These tools extract specific, openly accessible information such as public tweets, Facebook posts, YouTube videos, deep fakes, morphed media, fake news, misinformation, viral content spreading communal hatred, hashtags, trends, and propaganda material from YouTube channels and Telegram groups, it said.

The ministry also listed several operational uses of the technique, such as monitoring radical content, extremist ideologies, propaganda videos or bomb-making tutorials shared on public platforms. Tracking scam websites and links related to online gambling, fake job offers and fraudulent investment schemes, scrutinising public profiles on mat-



rimonial and dating platforms in cybercrime cases involving honey traps and blackmail and extracting cryptocurrency wallet addresses from dark web marketplaces during investigations.

The panel was also informed that artificial intelligence is now playing a central role in intelligence gathering and counter-intelligence operations. Key AI applications include face recognition, social media parsing, network analysis, natural language processing for structured and unstructured data, pattern recognition and entity resolution which helps accurately iden-

tify and link individuals across multiple public sources.

"AI is helping security agencies in enhancing their capabilities for intelligence gathering and counter-terrorism efforts by rapidly analysing vast datasets, detecting anomalies, predicting patterns, cross-linkages, etc., thereby improving decision-making, speed and accuracy," the ministry said.

The ministry highlighted that the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) is already using AI for narrative and sentiment analysis on open-source social media platforms. An "AI-driven intelligence fusion centre" for the

CRPF is in the final stage of deployment. Once operational, it will ingest massive volumes of structured and unstructured data and generate actionable analysis and decision-support solutions for operational requirements.

It added that AI can automate the processing of diverse data sources including communication records, open-source intelligence, financial transactions and surveillance feeds, enabling quicker threat identification, anomaly detection and linkage analysis. Natural language processing tools are particularly useful for multilingual monitoring, including regional dialects, and for decoding sensitive content from both the open and dark web.

The submission by the MHA before the parliamentary panel has come amid growing scrutiny over digital surveillance and data privacy. By emphasising that only publicly available information is accessed and no personal data is harvested, the MHA has sought to address concerns raised by the various groups.

DGCA chief Faiz Ahmed Kidwai transferred

RAJESH KUMAR ■ New Delhi

Three months after large-scale flight cancellations by IndiGo disrupted air travel across the country, the chief of the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) has been transferred.

The Appointments Committee of the Cabinet (ACC) has appointed Vir Vikram Yadav, replacing Faiz Ahmed Kidwai.

Yadav, an Odisha cadre IAS officer who replaces Kidwai at DGCA, is his batchmate and is currently serving as additional secretary in the Ministry of Environment, Forest, and Climate Change.

Kidwai, a 1996 batch IAS officer of Madhya Pradesh cadre, has been appointed as additional secretary in the Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT), according to an order by the ACC.

"Shri Vir Vikram Yadav, IAS (OR:96), Additional Secretary, Ministry of Environment, Forest & Climate Change as Director General, Directorate General of Civil Aviation, Ministry of Civil Aviation in the rank and pay of Additional Secretary to the Government of India by



keeping the Recruitment Rules of the post in abeyance vice Shri Faiz Ahmed Kidwai, IAS (MP:96) upon his appointment as Additional Secretary, Department of Personnel & Training, Ministry of Personnel, Public Grievances and Pensions," the order read. With this appointment, he will now head India's aviation regulator at a time when the sector is witnessing rapid expansion, increasing air traffic and ongoing safety oversight reforms.

The reshuffle comes at a crucial time for the aviation sector, with the DGCA closely

monitoring airline safety, fleet expansion, airport infrastructure readiness and regulatory compliance amid strong growth in domestic and international air travel. The DGCA is responsible for regulating civil aviation in India, including air safety, licensing, airworthiness, and operational standards, making the position one of the most important regulatory roles in the country's aviation sector.

Tuesday's appointments were part of a wider bureaucratic reshuffle approved by ACC. In the wake of the West Asia war, DGCA is keeping a close watch on airline operations as there are significant disruptions due to airspace curbs in the region as well as other operational challenges and rising fuel prices.

On the other hand, the watchdog has taken certain passenger-friendly measures. Carriers are set to offer at least 60 per cent of seats in a flight without levying any additional charge from April 20, as well as maintain a transparent seat allocation policy. Airlines have opposed the revised policy citing revenue loss concerns.

States Focus

New chapter in Jamnagar railway development

In a significant boost to railway infrastructure in Jamnagar, Prime Minister Narendra Modi virtually inaugurated the Kanalus-Jamnagar railway line doubling project. Completed at a cost of ₹257 crore, the project is part of a larger initiative under which railway projects worth ₹891 crore across Gujarat were dedicated to the nation via video conferencing. This development marks a historic moment for Jamnagar and Gujarat, aligning with Indian Railways' vision of modernisation and regional growth. The doubling of the Kanalus-Jamnagar section is expected to reduce operational delays and provide a more comfortable travel experience for passengers. Additionally, the increased speed and efficiency of freight trains will significantly benefit local trade and industries. According to the Divisional Railway Manager of the Rajkot Division, this project will usher in a new era of socio-economic transformation in Jamnagar and surrounding regions.

‘Make in India, Made for the World’ realised

Prime Minister Narendra Modi inaugurated the Keynes Semicon OSAT facility in Sanand, Gujarat, marking a major step towards advancing India's semiconductor and technology sector and strengthening the vision of self-reliance. During his one-day visit to Gujarat, the Prime Minister first inaugurated the Samrat Samprati Museum at the Jain pilgrimage site in Koba before proceeding to Sanand. At the facility, he inspected the chip production unit. Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw and Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel were also present. Addressing the gathering, the Prime Minister stated that the "Make in India, Made for the World" vision is now becoming a reality. He highlighted that a new bridge has been formed between Sanand and Silicon Valley, with the plant serving as an international module production hub for a California-based company. The modules produced here have already been booked for export, and intelligent power modules will further strengthen India's electric vehicle industry.

Samrat Samprati Museum inaugurated in Gujarat

Prime Minister Narendra Modi inaugurated the Samrat Samprati Museum at the Jain Tirth in Koba during his one-day visit to Gujarat, where he launched and laid the foundation stone for development projects worth over ₹19,800 crore. He was welcomed by Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel and Governor Acharya Devvrat, along with other dignitaries. The museum has been constructed with financial and strategic support from the UNM Foundation of the Torrent Group. The foundation has also taken responsibility for its future management and maintenance. Sudhir Mehta of the Torrent Group, who played a key role in realizing this project, stated that the museum will inspire future generations to gain deeper insights into India's spirituality, culture, and art.

Forces trap 2 unidentified terrorists in Jammu



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

At least two unidentified terrorists have been trapped by the joint team of security forces during a Cordon and Search Operation (CASO) in the central Kashmir district of Ganderbal late on Tuesday evening.

According to preliminary reports, a few gunshots were heard in the forest

area of Ahrama, Ganderbal, after the security forces launched a cordon and search operation. The CASO was launched after receiving inputs about the presence of some terrorists in the area.

Till the time of filing the report, the security forces have maintained a tight cordon, and additional troops have been rushed to the spot to further tighten the cordon.





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States Focus



Election flying squad inspects DMK chief Stalin's vehicle

DMK Chief MK Stalin's vehicle was intercepted and checked by the election flying squad while he was travelling to Tiruvur district for the election campaign on Tuesday. The inspection took place shortly after Stalin launched his election bid from Tiruvur constituency, the hometown of his father and late DMK patriarch M Karunanidhi, on Tuesday. The video clip released by the DMK shows the Chief Minister remaining seated in the vehicle while the officials conducted their search. Following the brief check, Stalin was permitted to resume his journey to meet with voters. The Model Code of Conduct came into effect with the Election Commission announcing the schedule for the legislative assembly elections on March 15. Elections to the 234 Assembly constituencies in Tamil Nadu are slated to be held on April 23. According to the EC, the surveillance teams deployed in Assembly constituencies have so far seized ₹273.71 crore, which include ₹44.89 crore cash, gold worth ₹116.07 crore, and liquor worth ₹93 lakh, a release said



PM, Shah visit TN frequently, not giving funds we ask: CM

Tamil Nadu Deputy Chief Minister Udhayanidhi Stalin on Tuesday took a dig at the "frequent" visits of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah to the State and alleged that they were denying State Government funds sought. Both leaders have not given any major projects for the state, he alleged and appealed to the people to "banish" the BJP from Tamil Nadu. Addressing an election rally in Harur Assembly constituency, where the DMK's A Shanmugam is contesting, Udhayanidhi said, "PM Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah are visiting Tamil Nadu frequently, but they are not giving any projects or even the funds that we ask. The BJP should be ousted from Tamil Nadu," he alleged. Though the DMK-led alliance lost Harur (to AIADMK) seat during the 2021 election, the party did not ignore development in the constituency and provided ₹400 crore worth road infrastructure projects, new buildings in Government hospitals, laid roads in hill areas, developed temple town and established ₹6 crore worth ITI in the constituency, Udayanidhi said.

Congress has brute majority: Vedyurappa



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Bengaluru

Veteran BJP leader BS Yediyurappa on Tuesday appealed to the voters of two Assembly seats going to bypolls, to defeat the Congress, claiming that the ruling party has a "brute majority" in the state, and a by-election win will let them indulge in more corruption, intoxicated with power.

Bypolls for the Bagalkot and Davanagere South Assembly constituencies will be held on April 9. The elections were necessitated following the deaths of senior Congress MLAs HY Meti and Shamanur Shivashankarappa, respectively.

"Today and tomorrow, I will campaign for our candidate Srinivas in Davanagere. On April 5 and 6, I will campaign for our candidate Charantimath in Bagalkot. I'm one hundred per cent confident that our candidates will win in both constituencies with a huge margin," Yediyurappa said.

Speaking to reporters here, he said, there is rampant corruption in Karnataka and Chief Minister Siddaramaiah has forgotten the welfare of the people and is running an administration in the state that resembles "Tughlaq Darbar".

Assam elections: BJP manifesto promises ₹5 lakh cr investment

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Tuesday released the BJP's manifesto for Assam Assembly polls, promising protection of land, heritage and dignity of indigenous people and ₹5 lakh crore infrastructure investment. BJP's 'Sankalp Patra' comprises 31 promises, including the recovery of encroached land from "Bangladeshi Miyas", bringing in Uniform Civil Code, and creating employment opportunities for youths.

The manifesto pledged to protect the land, heritage and dignity of the indigenous people of Assam by implementing the Immigrants (Expulsion from Assam) Act, 1950, to expedite the process of detection and pushback of illegal immigrants.

The BJP also promised that it would strengthen the legislative protections to preserve the civilisation, heritage and rights of the people of Assam by implementing the Uniform Civil Code (UCC), excluding the Sixth Schedule and Tribal areas, to ensure the rights of ethnic communities.

It pledged to "free every inch of land from encroachment by illegal immigrants and provide land rights to all genuine citizens of Assam" under the 'Mission



Sankalp Patra for BJP Assam released by Nirmala Sitharaman on Tuesday in Guwahati

PIONEER PHOTO

Basundhara' scheme.

The manifesto also assured that the BJP, if it returns to power in Assam, would free the encroached land parcels of Satras, Namghars, Devalayas and other places of worship.

The BJP will also formulate an effective law to end the menace of 'Love Jihad' and take firm measures to tackle the menace of 'Land Jihad', the party's manifesto said.

The party promised that ₹5 lakh crore would be invested to position Assam as India's Eastern Gateway, backed by the Asom Gati Shakti Master Plan, to ensure the timely completion of projects.

The saffron party also pledged to launch the 'Badh Mukh Assam Mission' with an investment of over ₹18,000

crore to make the State flood-free. The BJP will also provide 2 lakh Government jobs and create more entrepreneurial opportunities through various schemes.

Sitharaman said this manifesto was prepared on "a decade of transformation of the State, which the Congress could not achieve in 60 years".

"The Congress had no focus on long-term development of North East as that is what its politics is all about", she alleged. Massive development has taken place under the BJP rule in the state, the finance minister claimed, adding that "many young Assamese are leaving their global careers and returning to Assam, not out of compulsion but due to opportunities".

"Peace has been restored in Assam by the BJP", and the development is possible only when there is stability, she said.

"Assam lived with AFSPA for 32 years due to Congress policies, but the BJP ensured that the law was removed from most States," she added.

Among those present on the occasion were Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, Union ministers Sarbananda Sonowal and Pabitra Margherita, state BJP president Dilip Saikia, National vice president Baijyant Panda, state cabinet ministers and other senior party leaders.

Elections to 126 assembly constituencies in the state will be held on April 9, with counting on May 4.

CPI(M)-BJP understanding to block UDF return in Kerala, says Antony

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Thiruvananthapuram

Congress veteran AK Antony on Tuesday alleged a tacit understanding between the ruling CPI(M) and the BJP in Kerala, claiming that both sides were working to prevent the UDF from returning to power.

Addressing a press conference, Antony said there were clear indications of an "undercurrent" between the two parties, pointing to what he described as the "unusually warm reception" extended to Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan at Prime Minister Narendra Modi's office during



his visits to New Delhi.

According to him, leaders at the national level, including Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Union Home Minister Amit Shah and the RSS, were keen to ensure that the UDF does not return to power in

the southern State. "They are determined that there should not be another Congress Chief Minister in the South. To achieve that, they will extend support to the Marxist party in certain segments. Such an arrangement cannot be one-sided, and there would naturally be some return support as well," Antony alleged.

However, such tactics would not succeed this time, the former Defence Minister said. Projecting a decisive victory for the UDF in the April 9 Assembly polls, Antony said public sentiment had already turned against the ruling Left Democratic Front (LDF) Government.

Rahul alleges PM wants LDF to win Kerala polls



Rahul Gandhi addressing a public meeting ahead of the Kerala Assembly elections in Kallachi, Kerala

PTI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Kannur (Kerala)

Alleging a 'partnership' between the CPI(M) and the BJP in Kerala, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Tuesday claimed that Prime Minister Narendra Modi wants the ruling LDF to win the April 9 Assembly elections in the southern State.

Addressing an election rally, Gandhi reiterated his charge that the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) is fighting the combined forces of the Left Democratic Front (LDF) and the BJP. Two former CPI(M) leaders — V Kunhikrishnan and TK Govindan — who are contesting as independents with the support of the UDF, were also present on the stage.

"This election is a fight between two ideologies — that of the Left Front led by CPI(M) and that of the UDF. For the first time, we are seeing a partnership between the BJP and the Left Front," he said.

He said that it is quite surprising that a Left party is aligning with an extreme Right-wing party, because they have diametrically opposite ideologies. "So the question is, how is it possible that a Left party combines with a Right-wing party? This is like a puzzle," Gandhi said.

"Some answers to the puzzle are sitting on the stage. There are two veteran leaders from CPI(M) here today. Why are they sitting on our stage and not campaigning for CPI(M) and the chief minister?" he asked.

Gandhi alleged that what is today called the Left Front is no longer a Left or even a centrist formation.

"In fact, they are partnering with the BJP because they are corporate parties. They are no longer parties of the people. The proof is sitting on the stage now. People with Left-minded thinking are with the Congress, and the party is supporting them," he said.

CM Vijayan rejects SDPI support claims

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Thiruvananthapuram

Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan on Tuesday dismissed allegations that the ruling front sought SDPI backing in the April 9 Assembly polls as "baseless". Addressing reporters, Vijayan asserted that neither the LDF nor any of its candidates had reached out to the SDPI for electoral support, including in the Nemom constituency.



The Social Democratic Party of India is the political arm of the banned Islamic outfit Popular Front of India (PFI). Responding to queries over the SDPI's declared support to the ruling front in Nemom, where the LDF is locked in a keen contest with the BJP, Vijayan said the CPI(M), the LDF, or its candidate in the constituency had never sought such support.

"It is baseless. We have never sought any such support. We have never taken a stand seeking support from anyone outside the LDF. Our candidate in Nemom, Sivankutty, also did not make any such request," he said.

Voter list controversy in Bengal: Mamata Banerjee writes to CEC over suspicious Form 6 entries

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Kolkata/New Delhi

West Bengal Chief minister Mamata Banerjee wrote to Election Commission on Tuesday accusing the BJP of attempting to illegally include voters from outside the State in bulk by means of Form 6 electoral roll applications.

West Bengal Chief Electoral Officer Manoj Kumar Agarwal promised to review the CCTV footage of his office. The Election Commission accepts applications on Form 6 for registering new voters. It is a mandatory procedure which requires the furnishing of documents to prove the applicant's date of birth and residence address, besides other necessary identity papers. In

a strongly worded letter to Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, Banerjee termed the move "another coordinated attempt by the BJP, in conjunction with the Nirvachan Sadan, to interfere with the democratic rights of the people" after the "flawed and seemingly targeted SIR caused severe hardship to millions, pushing many to the brink of disenfranchisement".

The Trinamool Congress chief shot the letter in less than 24 hours after the party's national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee on Monday alleged that nearly 30,000 Form 6s were submitted by the BJP in a day to make residents of other states voters of West Bengal. Mamata Banerjee's letter

claimed receipt of "credible reports" that a large number of Form 6 applications were being "submitted by BJP agents at the office of the chief electoral officer (CEO) and across several districts".

Stating that these do not seem to be routine applications for voter inclusion but "a mischievous ploy to include non-residents in the electoral roll", the chief minister requested the CEC and not to entertain any such applications for inclusion after the publication of the final electoral roll on February 28.

"There are serious concerns that these applications may pertain to individuals who are not genuine residents of Bengal and who

have no legitimate connection to the state. Similar patterns were reportedly observed before elections in Bihar, Haryana, Maharashtra and Delhi," the TMC chief wrote to Kumar.

In view of the Model Code of Conduct in effect following the declaration of the assembly polls on March 15, Banerjee addressed the communication to Kumar on the TMC chairperson letterhead and not that of the chief minister.

The leader stated that she had "reasonable apprehensions" that the 30,000-odd applications would be "allowed by the Election Commission without giving appropriate notice to the concerned booths (sic) and to all the political parties".



West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee speaking during a public meeting in support of Trinamool Congress candidates from Bankura's Bishnupur organisational district ahead of the State Assembly elections, in Bishnupur on Tuesday

PTI



Order Order

HC rejects plea against EC's officer transfers in Bengal



The Calcutta High Court on Tuesday dismissed a PIL challenging the transfer of administrative and police service officers by the Election Commission in poll-bound West Bengal.

The EC transferred several officers, including the State's chief secretary, the home secretary and the DGP, immediately after the announcement of the Assembly election schedule for the State.

Claiming that these large-scale transfers would affect the running of the State's administration, the petitioner prayed that such orders by the poll panel be set aside.

A division bench presided by Chief Justice Sujoy Paul dismissed the petition.

The elections to the 294-member West Bengal Assembly will be held in two phases - on April 23 and 29. Votes will be counted on May 4.

HC seeks response on Sikh articles seized during Operation Blue Star

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

The Punjab and Haryana High Court has issued notices to the Army, the Centre and the CBI on a plea seeking directions for disclosure of manuscripts, religious books and other articles allegedly seized during Operation Blue Star and handed over to the Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC).

A division bench of Chief Justice Sheel Nagu and Justice Ramesh Kumari passed these directions on Monday while hearing the plea filed by a Ludhiana resident in 2019.

The petitioner sought directions to the SGPC for the whereabouts of the religious texts, manuscripts and other articles that were allegedly seized during Operation Blue Star and given to the SGPC.

Operation Blue Star was a military operation undertaken



between June 1 and June 10, 1984, against Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale-led armed militants who were holed up in the premises of the Golden Temple in Amritsar.

In November 2019, the high court issued a notice of motion to the SGPC only. But during subsequent hearings, the SGPC stated that some

items were returned, and some articles were still in the possession of the CBI, the Centre and the Army.

Petitioner Satinder Singh, who described himself as a devout Sikh, submitted that during Operation Blue Star, the articles were seized from the Sikh Reference Library, Toshakhana, Central Sikh

Museum and Guru Ramdas Library of the Golden Temple Complex. The petitioner sought directions for the preparation of lists of manuscripts, artifacts and literature removed on June 7, 1984.

The petitioner also sought directions for the preparation of a list of manuscripts, religious texts and other articles returned to the SGPC.

It was further prayed that manuscripts, religious books and other articles be restored to the libraries, the Central Sikh Museum and Toshakhana in the Golden Temple Complex.

These should be made available to the public for 'darshan', reading and research purposes, submitted the petitioner.

While issuing notices, the HC on Monday asked the respondents to file their replies on whether they are in possession of the articles.

Hyderabad Corporation seizes Jayalalithaa's house over tax dues



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hyderabad

The GHMC briefly seized a residential building owned by late Tamil Nadu Chief Minister J Jayalalithaa here over unpaid property tax dues, and released it on Tuesday after the caretakers assured to settle the arrears.

The G+4 (Ground Plus four floors) building at Srinagar Colony was seized on Monday by the Greater Hyderabad Municipal Corporation (GHMC) officials after its caretakers allegedly failed to respond to multiple notices regarding tax dues pending since 2017, said GHMC officials.

"We issued notices for payment of property tax dues, even visiting the premises several times. We had to seize it as per rules as there was no alternative," he said.

The property tax payable stood at over ₹82 lakh after

waiver of 90 per cent of interest, offered by GHMC, on the pending property tax.

The caretakers have sought vacancy remission as the building remained unoccupied since Jayalalithaa's death (in 2016). The request for vacancy remission (which provides for concession in property tax) has been accepted, said officials.

The building is in the name of Jayalalithaa, and its ownership would be transferred after the claimants submit the necessary proof.

Legal proceedings regarding the property's inheritance are going on. Though it is a residential building, it is now in the commercial category as it was rented out to a company promoted by Vijay Mallya in the past. The company, however, had vacated the premises in 2017, the officials added.

Supertech case: Regulator IBBI suspends insolvency professional's registration for 2 years

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Insolvency and Bankruptcy Board of India (IBBI) has suspended the registration of an insolvency professional for two years for multiple lapses in handling proceedings of Supertech Ltd and Nobility Estates.

In its order passed on March 30, the IBBI's disciplinary committee (DC) found that Hitesh Goel failed to perform his duties provided under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC) and related norms during the corporate insolvency resolution process of the two companies.

Supertech Ltd was admitted to insolvency proceedings in March 2022, with Goel appointed as the interim resolution professional (IRP) and later confirmed as the resolution professional.

Subsequently, the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) directed that insolvency proceedings be limited to the Eco Village 2 project, while other ongoing projects under the continued supervision of the IRP.

IBBI noted that Goel had failed to disclose key details in the Information Memorandum (IM) related to Eco Village 2 (EV-2), including the status of pending or completed towers or units, unsold



inventory, occupancy details and certificates.

Further, the IBBI observed that Goel failed to file the information memorandum, along with the CIRP Form-3

and did not conduct the first meeting of the Committee of Creditors (CoC) within the prescribed timeline.

There were also delays in filing avoidance applications

and circulating the minutes of the lenders' meeting to stakeholders in non-EV-2 projects.

In the Nobility Estates case, delays were observed in conducting the first meeting of CoC within the prescribed timeline, in appointing the registered valuers, in publishing Form-G, and in submitting the information memorandum, as per the order.

"Therefore, the DC in exercise of the powers conferred under Section 220 of the Code read with Regulation 13 of the IBBI (Inspection and Investigation) Regulations, 2017, hereby suspends the registration of Hitesh Goel for a period of two years," IBBI's Whole Time Members

Bhushan Kumar Sinha and Jayanti Prasad said.

Coming to the rescue of thousands of hassled homebuyers waiting for the delivery of their dream homes for almost two decades, the Supreme Court in February this year upheld an NCLAT order asking the state-owned NBCC to complete 16 housing projects of debt-ridden realty firm Supertech Ltd expeditiously.

The top court also restrained all Tribunals and High Courts from passing any order that may lead to the stalling of the construction work to be completed by the National Buildings Construction Corporation (NBCC) Ltd.

Industrialist Pawan Ruia arrested in multi-crore cyber fraud case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The Cyber Crime Wing of the West Bengal Police on Tuesday arrested industrialist Pawan Ruia in connection with his alleged involvement in a multi-crore fraud case involving shell companies and cryptocurrency-based money laundering, a senior officer said.

Ruia was apprehended near a hotel in New Town in the outskirts of Kolkata following a case registered at Bidhannagar Cyber Crime Police Station, he said. The



police have registered a suo motu case based on findings from their probe into cybercrime cases, with proceeds amounting to ₹315 crore allegedly traced to bank accounts of shell companies and individuals linked to the Ruia family, sources said.

The arrest comes after the Calcutta High Court earlier in the day vacated interim protection granted to the accused and his family members in the matter, clearing the way for police action, the police said.

NGT asks HPGCL to explore plantation at ash disposal site



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The National Green Tribunal (NGT) has asked the Haryana Power Generation Corporation Limited (HPGCL) to explore the possibility of having a dense plantation in the 152-acre area reclaimed after lifting fly ash from a disposal site. The green body is hearing the matter regarding the disposal of fly ash, a byproduct of coal-based power stations, lying at the site of the Faridabad Thermal Power Station (FTPS), a unit of HPGCL.

In an order dated March 25, a bench of NGT Chairperson Justice Prakash Shrivastava and expert members A Senthil Vel and Afrooz Ahmad noted that there were two ash disposal sites or ash

dykes, of which the old dyke, spread over 103 acres, had been remediated or settled, while the new dyke had been evacuated after the lifting of ash.

The bench said, "The record reflects that on remediation of the new ash dyke an area of 152 acres has been reclaimed by the HPGCL. If this area is not put to any other use, it should be utilised for the betterment of the environment."

"Therefore, HPGCL will explore the possibility of having a dense plantation, including the Miyawaki forest technique in that area."

The technique, pioneered by Japanese botanist Akira Miyawaki, focuses on recreating native forest ecosystems by planting a mix of indigenous tree species

densely and closely together, thereby accelerating forest growth up to 10 times faster and creating plantations that are 30 times denser than traditional methods.

The tribunal noted that Additional Solicitor General Vikramjeet Banerjee, appearing for HPGCL, said that the possibility would be explored.

"Hence, we dispose of the original application (OA) directing the HPGCL to submit the report before the registrar general in respect of the decision taken for utilisation of the reclaimed land for betterment of the environment within three months."

"If deemed necessary, the matter will be listed for consideration before the bench again," the tribunal said.

Bhojshala case: SC to hear on Wednesday plea against inspection of complex

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court is slated to hear on Wednesday a plea challenging an order of the Madhya Pradesh High Court, which said it will inspect the Bhojshala Temple-Kamal Maula Mosque complex in Dhar before April 2 in light of the "numerous disputes" pertaining to the ASI-protected structure.

According to the cause list of the top court, a three-judge bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi is likely to take up the appeal filed by Maulana Kamaluddin Welfare Society.

On March 16, a high court bench of Justices Vijay Kumar Shukla and Alok Awasthi had set April 2 for the regular hearing of the petitions related to the disputed Bhojshala Temple-Kamal Maula Mosque complex and said it will inspect the site.

On March 28, the two high court judges inspected the complex in Dhar. Justices Shukla and Awasthi of the Indore bench of high court had reached the site at around 1:50 pm and left at 2:45 pm.

The Hindu community considers Bhojshala to be a temple dedicated to Goddess Saraswati, while the Muslim side claims the 11th-century monument is the Kamal Maula Mosque.

As per an ASI order of April



Bhojshala-Kamal Maula Mosque complex

7, 2003, Hindus are allowed to worship at the complex every Tuesday, while Muslims are permitted to offer namaz every Friday.

The High Court, in its oral remarks, had said, "In view of the numerous disputes, we would like to visit the complex and inspect it. We will visit the complex before the next date (April 2)."

It, however, had clarified that no party involved in the case will be allowed to be present at the disputed site during this visit.

The disputed complex in Dhar is protected by the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI), which, following high court orders, conducted a scientific survey of it and submitted a detailed report.

The ASI's more than 2,000-page report has indicated that a large structure dating back to the reign of the Parmar kings of Dhar predated the mosque and that the

current disputed structure was built by reusing parts of ancient temples.

Retrieved architectural remains, sculptural fragments, large slabs of inscriptions with literary texts, Nagakarnika inscriptions on pillars, etc., suggest that a large structure associated with literary and educational activities existed at the site, according to the report.

Based on scientific investigations and archaeological remains recovered during the investigations, this pre-existing structure can be dated to the Paramara period, the report emphasised.

"Based on scientific investigations, surveys and archaeological excavations conducted, study and analysis of retrieved finds, study of architectural remains, sculptures, and inscriptions, art and sculptures, it can be said the existing structure was made

from the parts of earlier temples," the report stated.

From the art and architecture of the decorated pillars and pilasters, it can be said that they were part of earlier temples and were reused, while making colonnades of the mosque over a high platform of basalt, the ASI said in the report.

The Hindu community, which approached the court with the primary plea of determining the religious nature of the entire disputed complex, claims that coins, sculptures, and inscriptions found by the ASI during its scientific survey prove the structure was originally an ancient temple. The Muslim side, however, has disputed the claim and questioned the survey, alleging the ASI ignored its earlier objections and included "objects placed in the disputed complex" in the survey.

Catholic bishops' Conference of India writes to Amit Shah; flags 'serious concerns' over FCRA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Catholic Bishops' Conference of India (CBCI) has written to Home Minister Amit Shah flagging "serious concerns" over the proposed amendments to the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act (FCRA), urging wider consultation and safeguards against "excessive State control over civil society".

In identical communications to Shah and Members of Parliament (MPs) dated March 31, the CBCI said the FCRA Bill, 2026, while aimed at strengthening oversight, could upset the "constitutional balance, civil society

freedom and the future of charitable service in India".

The bishops' body raised particular concern over provisions that would allow foreign contributions and assets created out of such funds to vest in a designated authority not only in cases of cancellation or surrender of FCRA registration but also in cases of "deemed cessation", including non-renewal of licences.

It warned that this expansion could disproportionately affect organisations whose renewals are denied, especially as the renewal process is "totally controlled" by the Home Ministry.

It further said the deficiencies noticed by the department are

"not communicated to the association, and the associations are not granted an opportunity to make representations regarding the deficiencies on the basis of which the renewals are refused or denied".

Flagging constitutional issues, the CBCI said the proposed framework raises concerns under Article 300A relating to the right to property, pointing to the "absence of prior judicial determination before such vesting of assets," which it said departs from due process and proportionality. The memorandum also cautioned that the amendments could impact religious freedom under Articles 25 and 26, noting that faith-based organisations



across communities run schools, hospitals and social outreach programmes.

It said the lack of safeguards for charitable and educational institutions may lead to "undue interference in the internal management and service mission" of such bodies. Further, the body objected to provisions expanding liability to "key functionaries", arguing that this creates a presumption of culpability and could deter voluntary participation in civil society initiatives.

The CBCI also said organisations receiving foreign contributions are deeply engaged in service delivery among the poor, Dalits, tribal communities and in

remote areas, and warned that the proposed changes risk disrupting essential services.

In its appeal to the MPs and the Home Minister, the CBCI urged that the Bill be referred to a parliamentary standing committee for wider consultation, and called for safeguards to ensure that "administrative lapses do not lead to disproportionate penalties such as asset seizure".

It also sought provisions for judicial oversight, protection of institutional autonomy and the creation of an independent appellate authority, stressing that regulation "must not become excessive control or result in unintended expropriation".



Editor's
TAKE

Beyond the claim of a Naxal-free India

While security gains signal real progress, the deeper ideological roots and governance gaps endure, reminding us that the solution lies beyond statistics

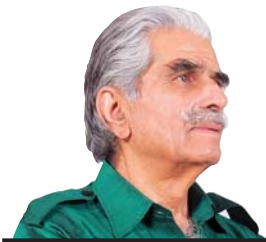
March 31, 2026 – the date the Central government set in 2024 – is now in the past. India is not yet free from Naxalism. No doubt the Government has done an incredible job of containing Naxalism and bringing down civilian casualties and violence, but it is yet to be eradicated completely. The promise of a “Naxal-free India” is yet to be realised. In the Lok Sabha, Amit Shah declared that the country had effectively been freed from Naxalism. Yet, beyond the rhetoric, the reality is more complex. While a large number of Naxalites have laid down their arms and the infamous Red Corridor has been cleared of Naxals’ sway over land and people, it is still present, albeit with a weak presence in pockets of central India, particularly in parts of Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand, and Odisha. The security operations have been very successful, and the Naxals are on the back foot. Infrastructure has improved, and the Naxals are finding it difficult to get new recruits as older ones are surrendering in large numbers. What has led to this decisive victory is not just security operations but a calculated approach combining force with development – roads, telecom connectivity, banking access, and welfare delivery – which has substantially shrunk the Red Corridor.

The Indian state has succeeded in regaining territorial and administrative control in most of the insurgency-hit areas. However, the complete eradication of Naxalism is yet to be attained. Naxalism was not a simple law-and-order situation. It was rooted in basic questions of land, livelihood, and injustices in the country’s most poverty-stricken areas of Chhattisgarh, Odisha, and Madhya Pradesh, mostly inhabited by Scheduled Tribes living in abject poverty. Shah’s assertion in the House - that poverty followed Naxalism, not the other way around - is rather oversimplifying a complex socio-economic reality. Tribal displacement, forest rights, skewed development, and unresponsive local governance continue to create fertile ground for discontent. While security forces may clear territories, the absence of sustained institutional presence - schools, healthcare, fair markets – can allow alienation to fester. If the gains made by security forces are to become permanent, these issues must be addressed immediately before another wave of this ideological war hits the region.

Moreover, counter-insurgency, especially one with deep social roots, demands consensus and continuity. The Government must incorporate the suggestions of Opposition parties and take them into confidence while waging a war on its own soil. When the discourse becomes combative rather than collaborative, it risks reducing a national challenge to a partisan contest. Rehabilitation programmes for former cadres must be strengthened to prevent relapse, and a drive must be undertaken to win hearts and minds through education, dialogue, and cultural integration, not just security dominance. Finally, the narrative itself needs recalibration. Declaring victory may be politically expedient, but it can breed complacency. The guns may have fallen quieter, but the battle of ideas – and of justice – remains unfinished.

Balen Shah unveils 100-reform agenda

Nepal has entered a dramatic new political phase, marked by an unprecedented crackdown on corruption and a generational shift in power. Prime Minister Balen Shah has already signalled that the new regime intends to match rhetoric with action



ASHOK K MEHTA

The assault on corruption and misgovernance has begun in Nepal. On March 28, in the first high-voltage act of PM Balen Shah, the government ordered the first-ever arrest of a former PM, KP Oli. I have been witnessing the entire election process in Nepal. To recap, elections were held on March 5; by 6/7 March it was eminently clear that the four-year-old Rashtriya Swatantra Party had swept the poll in both First Past the Post (FPTP) and Proportional Representation (PR) of Nepal’s mixed electoral system.

But it was only on March 25, that the seniormost lawmaker of the dissolved House, Nepali Congress’s Arjun Narsingh KC (NC coup-maker Gagan Thapa’s father-in-law), was sworn in by President Ram Chandra Poudel as lawmaker. The next day, 274 of 275 lawmakers, including RSP chairman Rabi Lamichhane, who is out on bail on charges of corruption, were sworn in by Narsingh KC. From Shah’s body language and protocol (Lamichhane was the last to arrive at the lawmaker oath-taking), it appeared that he recognised Lamichhane as the senior party colleague. Lamichhane proposed Shah as the leader of the parliamentary party. Despite speculation about a personality clash, leadership friction, and buzz about power-sharing, the December 28, 2025 Seven Point Agreement between Lamichhane and Shah contains no ambiguity about separation of power. Once Lamichhane is cleared of legal baggage, how he will be accommodated in the cabinet, if at all, remains a question mark.

Four-times PM Prachanda of the Nepal Communist Party also took oath, as three former PMs were missing, not given a ticket, while two others lost the election badly, including four-times PM KP Oli (oustured by the Gen Z revolt), whose popularity plummeted from ‘I love KP Oli’ to ‘Oli Chor Desh Chhod’. On March 27, at 12.34, with astrological precision, former rapper and Kathmandu Mayor Balen Shah took oath from Poudel as Vedic priests and Buddhist monks chanted hymns and verses at Shital Niwas, Poudel’s residence. Manual counting of two sets of votes, including in remote areas, took three weeks — a process which can be compressed.

Meanwhile, the outgoing Sushila Karki interim government released three reports, including the Judicial Commission recommendations by Gauri Bahadur Karki on the investigation of the 7/8 September Gen Z revolt resulting in 77 deaths and arson and looting worth USD 5 billion. Kantipur TV severely criticised the Karki Commission report as ‘selective justice’ (the report was first leaked by Jan Astha magazine) for excluding events and accountability for arson on September



BALEN SHAH’S TEAM HAS SET AN AMBITIOUS DEVELOPMENTAL AGENDA OF 100 REFORMS. THE GOVERNMENT’S FOCUS WILL BE INWARD-LOOKING, ATTEMPTING TO MAKE LIFE MORE CONVENIENT FOR ORDINARY NEPALESE AS NEPAL WILL SHORTLY EXIT FROM BEING A LEAST DEVELOPED COUNTRY

The writer, presently in Nepal, is a retired Major General, who served as Commander, IPKF (South), Sri Lanka

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8, which implicated Shah and Lamichhane.

The profile of the new House is stunningly different from any in the past except in 1960, when NC had a two-thirds majority in the 10-month-long tryst with democracy. RSP will have 182 lawmakers, two shy of a two-thirds majority, but no representation in the National Assembly or in any of the seven provinces. The second-largest party, NC, has 38 seats, with the rest of the opposition aggregating 55 seats. Communists and Madhesis are wiped out; only 15 per cent of lawmakers in the last House will be present in the new House; 96 are women, the highest number ever (37 per cent), with 37 per cent of the House being below 40 years of age. The 2015 Constitution, widely criticised for failing to provide a majority government, has enabled RSP to do precisely that. Since 1990, 33 governments have been formed, mainly coalitions, but since 2015, fractured coalitions. The 15-member Council of Ministers, including five women, is the smallest ever but has one big surprise: Gen Z leader Sudan Gurung, who brokered Shah’s entry into RSP, as Home Minister. None in the Shah team has been a minister before, including Finance Minister Swarnim Wagle, who has been in the Planning Commission of Nepal. Lack of experience may not be a handicap to their performance.

Most helicopter commentators are reimagining Nepal’s foreign policy. They say while a non-ideological and post-Communist government will present opportunities to external forces for expanding their political space, the RSP government will be able to expand its strategic autonomy. This is the first foray into foreign relations of a brand-new party since 1951. Fly-by-wire experts are misreading geography and forgetting a historic tenet set by the founder of modern Nepal, King Prithvi Narayan Shah in 1746: that Nepal is a pebble between two giant stones. Landlocked Nepal has two borders - with

China and India. The US and EU are two other external players. Every government in Nepal has invoked King Shah’s legacy using terms like ‘balanced diplomacy’ and Nepal ‘acting as a bridge between China and India’. RSP is calling it a ‘vibrant bridge’. The focus, as before, is on economics and ‘developmental diplomacy’. In its manifesto, RSP has merely changed the semantics of foreign policy.

An old tradition of ambassadors and eminent citizens congratulating the newly elected Prime

Minister and his Council of Ministers is being maintained. While the Indian ambassador, Naveen Srivastava, who will be leaving shortly, was leading the queue, the new Chinese ambassador Zhang Maoming not only shook Shah’s hand but engaged in a long conversation and handed over a letter inviting him to visit China. Which country, China or India, Nepal’s PM visits first is a very big issue. Every foreign policy move of this non-ideological PM and government will be carefully dissected to identify the tilt. For China, with Communist and Left lawmakers numerically reduced from 110 in the old House to 42 members at present, this is a cause for concern.

Balen Shah’s team has set an ambitious developmental agenda of 100 reforms. The government’s focus will be inward-looking, attempting to make life more convenient for ordinary Nepalese as Nepal will shortly exit from being a Least Developed Country.

Home Minister Gurung, who was the de facto leader of Gen Z and negotiated a number of agreements with the Karki government, is determined to prosecute the crusade against corruption, and already some former ministers have been arrested, and public response has been hugely positive. Former PMs Oli, Deuba, Prachanda, and some ministers will spend nervous nights as old files are dusted and closed cases reopened.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

PIC TALK



Farmers carry harvested bottle gourds on a boat through the River Ganga, in Prayagraj.

PHOTO: PTI



RAJYOGI BRAHMA KUMAR NIKUNJ JI

2ND OPINION

The air during the past few days has been heavy with tension and unease, with several regions witnessing rising geopolitical strain and strategic posturing. Visuals of escalating military movements, political warnings, and media debates have stirred memories of past conflicts. The whole world watched in shock as visuals emerged of missiles being fired from both sides of the region. There were a lot of deliberations among nations who were in support of this attack as well as among nations who were against this attack. However, the fact remains that the entire world lives under the shadow of nuclear threat, and this compels every nation to build up heavy stocks of weapons of mass destruction in the name of self-defence and security. In the present world many people consider survival and security as prime values. They argue that if a person does not survive, then what value

the other values have for him. In a similar vein, they further argue that if a person lives in a state of constant insecurity and fear, then what is the charm, the joy, the fun or the zest in living? Because the quality of life of a man in fear is like that of a man in a state of suspended animation and it’s not at all cherishable, relishable, enjoyable or valuable. On the other hand there are other people who question the contention of the former kind of people.

The questions they raise are that ‘after all what is the purpose of survival?’ & ‘what is the goal of life?’. Further they ask ‘what do we want to achieve by living or while living?’. They argue that the difference between a human being and an animal is narrowed down to zero if man also, like other animals, is concerned primarily and mainly about his physical survival only. They feel that there should be some higher and nobler aim of human existence & that there should be something more worthy for humans to be achieved. Arguing thus, they ask: If personal survival is the main value, then why do military men endanger their own survival or sacrifice their life at the battle-front in order to keep intact the sovereignty of the nation? Again, why did the heroes of Indian Freedom Struggle happily embrace death for the sake of independence of their motherland?

Why did kings in the olden times, give up their palaces and bodyguards and go to the forest in pursuit of truth, endangering their life, knowing well that there were tigers

and lions there? With these questions in mind, they further argue that why should man have fear if he has moral and spiritual strength and has good relations with all the human beings? Because fear, they assert, arises from guilt-consciousness, suspicion or enmity. So, man should be free from these negativities rather than have additional negative tendencies or emotion, namely fear because one’s survival should normally be an assured thing if one’s actions are in harmony with other beings, with the environment and with the moral and physical laws.

Each one of us must understand that our life and death, or survival and happiness, are governed by the law of karma. If our karma is good, why should we fear? Death will come to all one day, so there is no reason to live in fear. The world remains peaceless because mankind has not realised that the race for military power, weapons and domination of others is driven by religious bigotry, greed for power and revenge. Man forgets that the power of arms or money, without the power to control one’s own mind and senses, leads only to turmoil.

Lasting happiness depends not on dominating others but on mastering one’s own negative traits. If man does not destroy the demons of hate, anger and war with love and brotherhood, those demons will ultimately destroy mankind.

The writer is a spiritual teacher and a popular columnist

BALANCING WORK AND FAMILY IN UNCERTAIN MODERN TIMES

Apropos “Balancing work and family in an age of uncertainty” (March 31, 2026), the dilemma is instantly familiar. Technology, once a promise of freedom, has become a tether, pulling professional demands into kitchens and living rooms. The glow of a screen now competes with the warmth of family conversation, and the result is often silence punctuated by alerts.

Work no longer ends at the office door; it follows us home through emails, messages and virtual meetings. While technology has increased efficiency and flexibility, it has also quietly eroded the boundaries between professional and personal life. Many families now share the same space but not the same time or attention, which slowly

weakens emotional connections.

The latest rate of disruption is not measured in fuel prices alone but in the erosion of human presence. Global instability may raise costs, yet the greater expense is paid in neglected relationships and emotional distance within families. The cure is not elaborate: reclaiming rituals of togetherness, whether through shared meals, evening strolls, or candid conversations.

These small acts restore equilibrium, reminding us that resilience is cultivated at home. Balancing work and family is less about juggling hours than about choosing priorities, and the choice to be present remains the most valuable investment of all.

VEDA CHIDANAND | BENGALURU

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LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

War over oil interests

American President Donald Trump has created an energy crisis globally by attacking Iran. Now he is showing arrogant behaviour by threatening Iran with widespread destruction of its energy resources if a deal is not reached soon.

He wants to seize Kharg Island, Iran’s main oil terminal in the Persian Gulf. The American President has even threatened desalination plants that supply drinking water.

It is ironic that a Nobel Peace Prize seeker is acting recklessly by indulging in war. The irrational, illogical, unrealistic, arbitrary and aggressive attitude of Trump has not only put Iran in trouble but also those countries that buy oil from it. He should stop keeping his eyes on Iran’s oil reserves; otherwise, he will lose charm and reputation among his followers and countrymen due to his desperate and dictatorial attitude.

The President of the world’s strongest economy should maintain cordial relations with other countries and work towards global stability rather than threatening the destruction of civilian infrastructure. A ceasefire is the need of the hour to bring life back to normal and restore stability in the region.

ABHILASHA GUPTA | MOHALI

Fuel policy raises concerns

The ongoing conflict in West Asia has driven international crude oil prices to at least \$115 a barrel. The rupee-dollar exchange rate is rising and has crossed ₹95 to a dollar. The weakening rupee is contributing to the higher cost of imports.

In response, the Central government has cut the excise duty on petrol and diesel by 710 per litre each, supposedly to ease the burden of spiralling crude oil prices on the common man. However, current pump prices, and by extension retail prices, remain unchanged.

In the Union Budget 2026, revenue from Union Excise Duties is estimated at ₹3.89 lakh crore. Due to the downward revision of excise duty, budgetary revenue is expected to decrease significantly. Consequently, the central divisible pool for distribution to the States is likely to shrink. Analysts suggest that the duty cut may have aimed to maintain the earnings of oil marketing companies in the public sector and petroleum refiners and retailers in the private sector.

There is speculation that a massive hike in fuel prices after the upcoming Assembly elections is likely. India’s domestic crude oil production has also declined, indicating a lack of strategic intent.

HARIDASAN RAJAN | KERALA

Red terror nearly ended

Home Minister Mr Amit Shah’s statement that the ‘shadow of red terror has been lifted’ will be greeted with cheers by the nation, with the announcement coming a day before the deadline of March 31, 2026 set by the BJP government for its eradication.

Naxalism was born in 1967 as an offshoot of the CPI(M), with the goal of overthrowing the Indian government through armed insurgency and guerrilla warfare to establish a Maoist communist state. It sought to redress the grievances of the poor and landless farmers by eliminating feudal exploitation, redistributing land to them and destroying democratic institutions to establish a new state governed by the proletariat.

Though the aim was utopian, the means adopted were senseless violence, with Naxalites carrying out several attacks against security forces and killing prominent politicians like Congress leader VC Shukla in 2013.

Any anti-national movement that believes in the violent overthrow of elected governments has to be crushed firmly. The government has remained steadfast in following this policy against Maoists and terrorists.

V JAYARAMAN | CHENNAI

Kuwait: Nation Chooses Peace, Encounters Harsh Consequences

Kuwait calls on Iran to cease its attacks on the GCC and Arab states — not in the language of ultimatum, but in the language of reason. The path to security in this region does not run through missiles and drones

FIRST
Column



MISHAL
MUSTAFA
AL-SHAMALI

On this solemn occasion, we extend our deepest condolences on the passing of Indian national Santhansa Krishnan, who tragically lost his life while carrying out his professional duties at a power generation and water distillation facility in the State of Kuwait. We convey our heartfelt sympathies to his family and loved ones during this difficult time and wish a swift and full recovery to all those injured in the incident. The loss of innocent life underlines the human cost of instability and reinforces the urgency of restoring peace.

The State of Kuwait maintains a balanced and cautious position on the ongoing conflict in the region. It has consistently opposed escalation and any form of confrontation that leads to destruction and human suffering. Kuwait is not a party to military conflicts between nations; rather, it remains firmly committed to preserving the security and stability of the Gulf, the broader region, and the international community. This principled stance reflects Kuwait's longstanding belief that dialogue, diplomacy, and mutual respect must guide international relations.

Kuwait reiterates its strong condemnation of the Iranian aggressions witnessed over the past month against Kuwait, as well as against other Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) and Arab nations. These actions constitute a flagrant violation of Kuwait's sovereignty and a clear breach of international law, humanitarian principles, and the United Nations Charter. Respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity is not optional - it is a foundational principle of the international system.

In this context, the State of Kuwait affirms its inherent right to self-defence under Article 51 of the United Nations Charter. This right is exercised in response to clear and repeated acts of aggression, and always within the framework of international law. Kuwait remains committed to taking all necessary measures to safeguard its territory, citizens, and residents, while avoiding escalation and maintaining a responsible and measured approach. Kuwait has consistently and transparent-



THE WORLD IS WATCHING. AND THE WORLD MUST SPEAK — CLEARLY, COLLECTIVELY, AND SOON. AT THIS CRITICAL JUNCTURE, THE PATH FORWARD MUST BE GUIDED BY RESTRAINT, RESPECT FOR SOVEREIGNTY, AND A RENEWED COMMITMENT TO DIPLOMACY. THE STAKES ARE TOO HIGH — FOR THE REGION AND FOR THE WORLD — TO ALLOW ESCALATION TO DEFINE THE FUTURE

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ly communicated to the Iranian authorities that it will not permit its territory or airspace to be used as a platform for launching attacks against Iran. Despite these assurances, hostile actions have continued. Iranian aggression against Kuwait and neighbouring countries has manifested through the launch of ballistic missiles and drones targeting civilian infrastructure. These attacks have resulted in tragic loss of life, destruction of residential areas, and widespread damage to essential facilities.

Critical civilian infrastructure has been directly affected, including Kuwait International Airport, where disruptions to air traffic have impacted both regional connectivity and humanitarian movement. Water reservoirs, energy and power installations, private residences, and seaports have also been targeted - facilities that serve civilian populations and have no connection to military operations. Such actions not only violate international humanitarian norms but also exacerbate instability in an already fragile environment.

The Gulf states remain united in their position: they do not seek to be drawn into broader conflicts and continue to support all efforts aimed at de-escalation and peaceful resolution. They are closely monitoring developments and remain hopeful that ongoing diplomatic initiatives will bring an end to aggression and restore stability. Unity among Gulf nations reflects a shared commitment to peace, security, and collective resilience.

The prolonged continuation of conflict poses grave risks beyond the immediate region. The global economy and international trade are already experiencing strain. Iran's suspension of maritime navigation through the Strait of Hormuz has disrupted critical energy shipments, affecting countries far beyond the Gulf. The resulting volatility in energy markets has translated into tangible hardships, including shortages of essential supplies such as cooking fuel in several regions.

Moreover, rising energy and petrochemical prices threaten to reach unprecedented levels if the conflict persists. Disruptions to fertiliser shipments further compound the problem, placing agricultural cycles at risk in multiple countries. These cascading effects highlight the interconnected nature of today's global economy, where regional instability can quickly evolve into a worldwide crisis.

It is important to recall that GCC nations have, in the past, stood in solidarity with Iran during times of crisis and have condemned external aggression against it. The current escalation against neighbouring states, therefore, represents a troubling departure from principles of mutual respect and regional cooperation. Such actions erode trust and undermine the foundations of peaceful coexistence.

Kuwait emphasises that continued aggression against GCC and Arab states constitutes a serious threat to regional and

international peace and security. The international community must adopt a clear and unified stance in upholding international law and deterring actions that destabilise the region. Silence or inaction in the face of such violations risks normalising behaviour that endangers global stability.

In this regard, the State of Kuwait and its regional partners deeply appreciate the principled position taken by the Republic of India. India's consistent advocacy for peace, dialogue, and respect for international norms reflects its growing role as a responsible global actor. Its voice carries weight not only in the region but also on the international stage.

Kuwait, alongside GCC nations and Jordan, also values India's contribution during the emergency session of the United Nations Human Rights Council held in Geneva on March 25, 2026. India's emphasis on protecting civilians and safeguarding critical infrastructure, particularly in the energy sector, underscores the importance of prioritising humanitarian considerations even amid conflict. Equally significant is the call to ensure the security of global supply chains, which remain vital to economic stability and food security worldwide.

The global community continues to call upon Iran to comply fully with United Nations Security Council Resolution 2817, which condemns aggression and threats



From Hormuz to the household: Why India needs a new energy security doctrine



MEGHA
JAIN

SURABHI
SINGH

A missile strike in the Strait of Hormuz may seem distant until it shows up in the price you pay at the petrol pump. For India, this is not a hypothetical scenario but a recurring economic reality. In an increasingly interconnected world, geopolitical disruptions travel quickly through energy markets, landing squarely in household budgets.

The shock of Russia's invasion of Ukraine in 2022 is a case in point. As global crude prices surged, India's import bill ballooned, driving inflation across sectors. For a country that imports nearly 85% of its crude oil, exposure to such external shocks is not incidental; it is structural. What appears to be a distant conflict can, within weeks, reshape domestic economic conditions from metropolitan centres to small towns. Energy security is no longer just an economic concern; it is a national strategic imperative. India must move beyond reactive measures to a coherent energy security doctrine that anticipates and absorbs global shocks.

The anatomy of exposure

India's energy map is, in many ways, a map of geopolitical risk. Nearly a fifth of global oil trade passes through the Strait of Hormuz, and a significant share of India's crude imports traverses this narrow corridor. Any escalation involving regional powers, particularly Iran, has immediate implications not only for physical supply but also for global price benchmarks through heightened risk premiums.

A similar fragility defines the Red Sea corridor. Since late 2023, attacks on commercial shipping have forced vessels to reroute around the Cape of Good Hope, increasing transit times, freight charges, and insurance costs. These ripple through supply chains, functioning as an "invisible tax" on importing economies like India. Disruptions thousands of kilometres away translate into higher landed costs of crude, which then filter through the domestic economy.

Oil shocks are transmitted rapidly and widely. A spike in crude prices raises transportation and logistics costs, pushing up prices across



sectors — from manufacturing inputs to agricultural produce. Fertiliser costs rise, food prices follow, and inflation becomes embedded at the household level. The macroeconomic consequences are equally significant: a higher import bill widens the current account deficit, pressures the rupee, and increases the cost of dollar-denominated imports, compounding the initial shock.

Even modest price changes carry substantial weight. A \$10 per barrel rise can add an estimated \$14-15 billion to India's annual import bill. For policymakers, this means tighter fiscal space and heavier subsidy burdens; for MSMEs, compressed margins and reduced competitiveness. India has managed past disruptions through calibrated taxation and opportunistic sourcing, but in a world of frequent and overlapping geopolitical crises, such measures amount to cushioning, not resilience.

Strengths Without a System

India has taken meaningful steps to reduce its vulnerability. Following the Ukraine conflict, it increased imports of discounted Russian crude, at one point accounting for over a third of total imports. Supplier diversification has expanded to include the United States, Brazil, Guyana, and parts of West Africa. Domestically, ethanol blending in petrol has crossed 12 per cent, and renewable energy capacity has surpassed 200 GW, with solar playing a leading role.

Yet these gains remain fragmented. India's Strategic Petroleum Reserves (SPR) cover only about 9-10 days of demand — modest compared to the United States' roughly 60 days or China's approximately 70-80 days. In a prolonged disruption, such as a sustained Hormuz blockade, these buffers would offer limited protection. The challenge is not the absence of policy action but the lack of integration. India's energy strategy

must evolve from a set of discrete initiatives into a unified, doctrine-driven framework.

Towards a doctrine

India's next phase of energy security must rest on four strategic pillars.

First, diversify supply at scale — extending long-term partnerships beyond the Gulf to the Americas, Africa, and Central Asia, while institutionalising energy diplomacy.

Second, expand strategic reserves urgently, targeting at least 15-20 days of cover in the near term, supported by public-private participation and clear drawdown protocols.

Third, secure maritime energy routes - from Hormuz to the Strait of Malacca — through enhanced naval capabilities and closer coordination with strategic partners. Fourth, accelerate the clean energy transition: expanding renewables, scaling green hydrogen, and promoting electric mobility are not merely climate goals but strategic hedges against oil dependency. Together, these measures shift India's posture from managing shocks to pre-empting them.

Every global conflict today carries an economic cost for India — not always visible in headlines but felt acutely in household budgets. Energy costs — from petrol to cooking gas — have become a real-time indicator of geopolitical instability. India has both the capacity and the opportunity to change this equation. By embedding energy security at the core of national strategy, it can transform a structural vulnerability into strategic resilience. The next oil shock is not a question of if, but when. Preparedness must be built accordingly.

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Living between two democracies, voting in none



RACHITA
RAMYA

Whoever said you couldn't be in two places at the same time was wrong. Immigrants live in exactly that condition, constantly split between two worlds.

There is the host country, where they build their lives and livelihoods, and the home country, where their roots remain. Between the two lies a complicated process of acculturation - part assimilation, part erasure - never entirely complete.

Their identity becomes a shapeshifting, complex mass, shaped by the cultures, regions, and people they encounter. Anything that happens in the home country, from sociopolitical tensions to public health crises, from the governance of a political party to even the threat of war, indirectly affects them. At the same time, developments in the host country, such as immigration laws, economic shifts, job market instability, and rising taxes, shape their everyday realities just as deeply.

Yet, despite being deeply affected by both, immigrants often have no meaningful political voice in either.

India today has one of the largest immigrant diasporas in the world, with over 32 million people of Indian origin living abroad, according to the Ministry of External Affairs. Yet the number of those able to participate in Indian democracy remains strikingly small. In the 2024 general elections, only about 119,000 overseas Indians were registered as voters, and of those, just 2,958 reportedly travelled to India to cast their vote.

That is not low participation. It is near exclusion. The reasons are structural. While overseas Indians can register as voters, the law requires them to be physically present at their designated polling booth. For many, this is not a simple matter of booking a flight. Visa restrictions, work commitments, financial costs, and immigration-related constraints make it extremely difficult to return to India solely to vote. For those on temporary work visas, even short travel can carry professional and legal risks.

At present, there is no provision for online voting and no postal ballot system for most non-resident Indians. Proposals for proxy voting and remote voting mechanisms have been discussed in Parliament and by the Election Commission for several years, but they remain largely unimplemented. In effect, the right to vote exists, but access to it does not.

At the same time, in the countries where they live and pay taxes, millions of immigrants, including H-1B visa holders, international students, and

even long-term green card applicants, have no voting rights at all. In the United States alone, there are over 2 million Indians, many of whom are part of the highly skilled workforce in sectors such as technology, healthcare, and academia. They contribute significantly to economic growth and innovation, yet remain outside the democratic process.

The result is a quiet but profound disenfranchisement. The irony is stark. Immigrants are shaped by the politics of both their host and home countries, yet remain largely excluded from the political processes of either. They contribute economically, intellectually, and culturally, yet have little say in how systems function.

They pay taxes to structures they have no hand in shaping.

They exist in the messy in-between, where "immigrant" is no longer just a status, but a defining identity.

They live in a political limbo, neither here nor there. On one side, immigrants in countries like the United States help drive key industries, from Silicon Valley to public health systems, yet remain excluded from voting. On the other, their connection to India often deepens with distance. Many become more attentive to Indian politics, more emotionally invested in national identity, and more engaged in public discourse than when they lived in the country.

Yet they remain largely excluded from shaping its political future in any meaningful way.

They become, in a sense, political orphans.

The sharpest minds — engineers, doctors, researchers — find themselves subject to policies they cannot influence, waiting on administrations they cannot elect, and living under decisions they cannot shape. Travel costs, job constraints, and immigration restrictions make participation in home-country elections impractical for most, widening the gap between citizenship and civic agency.

This is not just brain drain.

This is vote vain, a loss not merely of talent, but of democratic voice. The messiness of being in two places, but in reality, the politics of being nowhere.

India received over 125 billion dollars in remittances in 2023, the highest in the world, much of it sent by this very diaspora. Immigrants continue to sustain families, communities, and even national economies from afar. Yet their political voice remains muted. You don't realise the weight your name carries until someone calls you by it. In the same way, you don't realise the power of your vote until it is taken away or rendered impossible to use. This is the problem haunting so many Indians abroad, and it needs real solutions and structural policies, not more waiting.



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BLASÉ CAPITAL

BLACK IN RED SEA

The Strait of Hormuz in the Middle East remains as twisted as ever. The US President Donald Trump told his advisors that he was open to ending the Iran war, even if there was no agreement on the opening of this strategic strait. It should have boosted sentiments. It only restrained global crude prices from rising, although several asset classes behaved violently, with equities up in the US, and stocks down in India. Despite the central bank’s pressure tactics, the rupee took a beating. The markets have heard similar good news from Trump several times. They now await actions, not talk, ground activity, not online texts. Hence, the global attention is still on the Strait, and its future, and whether oil and gas (liquefied one) will lurch back to normal over the next few months. However, the fortunes of the Strait are linked to the Red Sea.

Media reports indicate that “Iran is actively encouraging the Houthis (Iran-backed rebels in Yemen) to prepare for a renewed campaign against shipping in the Red Sea.” The objective to expand and enhance the oil-linked leverage that Tehran enjoys against Washington and Jerusalem. If both the Strait and Sea are effectively shut, the oil and economic crises will escalate to another level, and force the hands of Trump, who anyway seeks a quick exit from the Strait. According to media reports, “The Houthis have already shown their willingness to escalate. Their missile launches towards Israel for the first time during the ongoing conflict... marks a symbolic entry... More importantly, they have warned that they could target vessels passing through the Bab el-Mandeb Strait, a narrow maritime choke point linking the Red Sea to the Gulf of Aden.” Two chokepoints, two straits under siege, and the crisis may blow up exponentially, and drag the US in its war waves.

What is crucial to remember is that the Houthis have done this successfully in the past, albeit before the Iran war. Between 2023 and 2025, according to independent figures, they attacked more than 100 ships, and forced firms to reroute the vessels around South Africa. It raised costs, increased journey time, and spiked insurance. This is exactly what has happened in the case of Strait of Hormuz, except that in this instance the added complication, the major one, is supply disruptions to almost a fifth of the crude oil supplies. Indeed, at present, the Red Sea has emerged as an alternative route to ship oil from Saudi Arabia, which has ramped up production and shipments through a pipeline to a port in the Red Sea. If 25 per cent of oil passes through the Strait of Hormuz, 15 per cent of maritime trade, including oil, passes through the strait in the Red Sea. A double choke point may squeeze Trump’s arm, and possibly other more dangerous places.

For Trump, the saving grace is what he did last year, and we know it well. America launched sustained air strikes against the Houthis and Yemen in 2025. The latter’s economy is still reeling under the shock, and the Houthis are still to regroup to get back to their original strength. After what happened to Iran, although Iran countered, and fought back like a wounded tiger, the Houthis are cagey and doubtful. They want to help Iran, and the attacks on Israel prove it, but they do not wish to target American or Sadi assets, and prod another mad tiger. At present, the US and Saudi Arabia believe that the Houthis will not go that far, and this is what they have communicated to the scared Europeans. But things are changing fast in this fast-changing war. Actions, decisions, texts, and statements are getting garbled. The Houthis can lose grip over the situation, and get entangled in a new sub-war as the messages get lost in translation, and smoke-and-fire.

According to officials, who spoke to a media agency, “The longer the US-Israel war against Iran goes on, the more likely the Houthis are to target the Red Sea.” This, according to the agency, “creates a ticking clock dynamic, where prolonged conflict increases the probability of a second shock.” Even the attacks are not required. Mere threats by the Houthis, and small actions will terrorise the world of oil, and the Red Sea may turn black without changing its colour. Shipping firms, nations, and insurance firms will reassess their options at the mere whiff of another threat, and oil markets may boil over. The global prices, which have steadied due to regular statements of peace, followed by acts of war, may lose their patience, and skyrocket. If oil reaches \$150 a barrel, it will be a different ball game. Economies will brace themselves for a wild ride. So will the policy-makers.

For India, the problem is acute, as apart from the Strait of Hormuz, the Red Sea and Suez Canal handle a significant portion of trade with Europe. If the Middle East trade is stalled due to Hormuz, and European one due to the Red Sea, New Delhi will be in grave trouble. “In effect, India would be hit on several fronts, rising import costs, disrupted export routes, and oil prices rising further.”

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | WEDNESDAY | APRIL 1, 2026

BUSINESS

10

Animal spirits hound the rupee

Rupee gains, loses, and gains again on a single manic Monday

One is not sure which animals are involved. They can be pure-bred bulls, standing bears, sheep in the clothing of the two, half-bull-half-bears, half-bear-half-bulls, wolves, foxes, jackals, or tigers. However, the result is evident. The rupee is under tremendous attack by animal-spirited investors, even as others defend it staunchly. One has seen the pattern repeatedly over the past several months. There are days when the rupee dips, and there are those when it perks up. Yet, maddening Monday (March 30, 2026) was one of the rare days when the animals came together to the currency jungle.

They played their wild games, the rupee was tossed around from one jaw to another, different sets of teeth pulling and biting it, even as there were some animals who rode on its back, and whose back the rupee rested on for a few seconds. Thank God, Tuesday (March 31) was a holiday, and the markets were closed. Hence, one does not know what kind of mania, speculation, manipulation, split-personality, paranoia, and madness will engulf it today. Remember, today may be the worst, or the most clownish day, being April 1, the fool’s day.

Everyone knew that the rupee will regain its much-lost strength on Monday. It was evident, logical, and expected. The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) clamped down on the short positions of the banks, and asked them to unwind them by April 10. The no-limit regime would change to a daily one of \$100 million, which meant that each bank could not exceed it. The unwinding would imply getting rid of the positions, even if it meant losses, and less selling pressures on the

rupee. By default, the rupee would leap out of the battering table.

It did. On the morning of Monday, the rupee immediately gained more than a rupee, and found itself in the ₹93-to-a-dollar zone. This was an unprecedented gain of more than a per cent, almost 1.5 per cent. To put it in perspective, the normal historical dip in the currency is four per cent a year, yes, in 12 months. In the recent past, it lost four per cent in a month. Yet, more than one per cent, not in a day, week, or month, but within hours was a shocker. A pleasant one for the central bank, and policy-makers, and a repulsive one for the banks, and speculators.

Of course, if the story had stopped then, and the rupee had stabilised at the same or similar levels through Monday, there would not be much of a story. It was an expected climax, although the heights of the recovery were more than the estimations and predictions of one per cent until April 10. But as the day progressed, another anti-climax gripped the rupee, and began to squeeze the air out of its lungs. The rupee plunged down, as if there was no Tuesday. It breached ₹95, from the over ₹93 level, and a wilder speculative dance was visible.

Another defeat for the central bank! While most of the investor-animals were planning to take a break, relax a bit after the massive seesaw battles between the bulls and bears, for the other animals, and many in different clothing and disguises, there was the last climax to unfold. The directors of this never-ending-

excitement, and writers of this edge-of-the-seat plots and sub-plots were not done. Towards the end of Monday, the supporters of the rupee came back with a vengeance, and with a never-imagined-before force. It was jungle raj, where the power equations changed rapidly, several times, within a day.

When the drama was over, each animal was tired and exhausted, the rupee gained massively, almost another rupee, which was like more than one per cent. In the craziness, the currency gained by a per cent, lost by more than two per cent, and gained another per cent. In effect, the rupee moved four per cent up and down, like a wild roller coaster ride. In essence, the rupee did in a single trading session

what it has historically done over 12 months, or 30 days. It was a day like never before, and one that one hopes does not repeat itself.

After the day was over, or while it was still on, the policy-makers began to verbally defend the rupee. Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said that there was nothing wrong with the currency since the plunge one has witnessed over the past few months and years is less compared to how the other Asian currencies fared. In comparison, the downward movement of the rupee is less than the others. She highlighted that the strength of the economy, fiscal position, prudent deficit management had earned global praise. “Compared to other emerging economies, the rupee is doing fine. Absolutely fine,” she explained.

One knows that the RBI’s decision to force banks to unwind the short positions, down to \$100 million per bank per day by April 10 was to stem or stall the speculation in the rupee. Yet the minister of state for finance categorically said that the currency’s value is “determined by market forces, and influenced by multiple global and domestic factors.” He admitted that the Government and central bank had the rupee on their radar, and were monitoring the daily gyrations. Hence, the central bank may intervene, but it will do so strategically and irregularly.

However, apart from the daily movements, let us look at the currency in perspective. Between 2004 and 2014, the rupee’s slide was a third, from ₹45 to ₹60 to a dollar. Between 2014 and now, the downward glide is more than 60 per cent, to ₹95. Some experts contend that the lowest level may be ₹100, although there will be several ups and downs, before it reaches it, if it does. Logically, one can assume that as India has gained in terms of economic growth, and prosperity, the currency was beaten and thrashed, as it went downhill.

Over the years, the various regimes, and the central bank, especially after reforms, have maintained that the exchange rate is determined by the market forces. There is never a target that the RBI has in mind, and it allows it to settle down on the relevant level. The RBI contends that its role is to manage volatility, and speculations, as it did with the limit on short positions, and it does not defend a specific exchange rate. But no regime wants to see the currency in a free fall.

OUR TAKE

A Contrarian Investor

‘Lotto’ to play for in the jackpot

Play the same number, and chances go up. Nah, it is blah, blah

odds become manageable, and the likelihood of a win increases to, say, 1:1 million, or even less. Each day, Lotto 47 or similar jackpot is held, the odds remain the same. Nothing happens to them, even if you bet on 10 sets of the same numbers every day.

The reason, yet again, is simple. Each day’s jackpot is a unique event. There is no connection between today, tomorrow, or yesterday, as far as the odds are concerned, even if you play every day. The odds in Lotto 47’s case remain nearly 1:11 million every day. The machine picks up a random set of numbers every day, and it does not matter whether you bet yesterday, or for the last 20 years, or 100 years. The odds of landing a specific six-digit set remains 1:11 million. Hence, the win by the Florida woman had nothing to do with dedication or patience.

Similar rules apply to buying a ticket every day. The odds do not come down because you have bought the ticket 1,000 times, or 10,000 times. The winning number is randomly decided each day, and it has nothing to do

with what happened yesterday, or what will happen tomorrow. Of course, this is true of games and lotteries, which have huge stakes, but even larger odds. In Lotto 47, the woman won a million dollars but played against odds of nearly 11 million. It is only when the odds are extremely low that dedication and patience may pay off.

Consider the game of cricket, where a bettor bets on India’s win in each match that India plays. Since the odds here are extremely low, 50 per cent, or one in two, consistently betting on India will ensure some sure wins. In the beginning, the win ratio may not be one in two, but maybe one in 100, as each coin can land a ‘heads’ for 100 times in a row. But, over time, over 1,000 of matches, or tens of thousands of coin tosses, the ratio will settle at around one to two. Indeed, a cricket bettor, over 10-15-20 years, can expect to call it right half the time.

According to a probability-investment website, “Of course, someone has to win the jackpot. But do not let that certainty cloud

your judgment. The rules of probability dictate you do not increase your lottery odds by playing more frequently (or betting on the same set of numbers for years), nor by betting larger amounts on each drawing. Each lottery ticket has the same odds of winning no matter how many you buy. Each one has an independent probability not altered by the frequency of plays, or how many other tickets you bought for the same drawing.”

In the same vein, consider the costs of the strategy of the pickup driver, or the Florida woman. The latter bet on the same set of numbers for years. Even if she paid \$10 each time, and played 10,000 times, she spent \$1,00,000 in the bargain. Her win amount was just a tad above this figure, which is not so great. The driver bought a raffle ticket every month for 15 years. In Dubai, the price is 1,000 AED (nearly \$275) to win a million dollars. Our driver purchased 180 tickets in 15 years, or spent nearly \$50,000. He won a million dollars, which is great. But as we maintain, and repeat, his win was not a given one. He was merely lucky. This is the gist of the lottery. It is pure, damn luck.

The Pioneer

SINCE 1865

Gas prices in US soar past \$4 per gallon, highest since 2022

WYATTE GRANTHAM-PHILIPS
■ New York

US gas prices jumped past an average of \$4 a gallon for the first time since 2022 on Tuesday as the Iran war pushed fuel prices to soar worldwide.

According to motor club AAA, the national average for a gallon of regular gasoline is now \$4.02 — over a dollar more than before the war began. The last time US drivers were collectively paying this much at the pump was nearly four years ago, following Russia's invasion of Ukraine. The price is a national average, meaning drivers in some states have been paying well over \$4 a gallon for a

while now. Prices vary from state to state due to factors ranging from nearby supply to differing tax rates.

Since the US and Israel launched a joint war against Iran on February 28, the cost of crude oil — the main ingredient in gasoline — has spiked and swung rapidly. That's because the conflict has caused deep supply chain disruptions and cuts from major oil producers across the Middle East.

Higher gas prices are impacting consumers and businesses as many households continue to face wider cost of living strains. And as drivers pay more to cover necessities like gas, many may be forced to cut their

budgets in other places.

More expensive fuel can also push up other spending, from utility bills to the price of many goods consumers buy each day.

In the immediate future, analysts point to groceries, which have to be restocked frequently and could also see price hikes as businesses' transportation costs pile up.

But hauling other cargo and packages has also been impacted. The United Postal Service, for example, is seeking a temporary 8 per cent added charge on some of its popular products including Priority Mail.

Diesel, the fuel used for many freight and delivery trucks, is now going for an



average of \$5.45 a gallon, up from about \$3.76 a gallon before the war began, per AAA.

If the war drags on, it's possible that those prices could tick up even higher. Most tanker movement in the key Strait of Hormuz, where roughly one-fifth of the

world's oil typically sails through, remains at a halt.

That's led to cuts from major producers in the region who have no way of getting their crude to market. Meanwhile, Iran, Israel and the US have all struck oil and gas facilities, worsening supply concerns. In a search

for some relief, the International Energy Agency pledged to release 400 million barrels of oil from emergency stockpiles of member nations. That includes the US, despite Trump initially downplaying the need for reserve oil.

The Trump administration has also eased sanctions to free up some oil from Venezuela, and temporarily Russia. The White House also says it's waiving maritime shipping requirements under a more than century-old law, known as the Jones Act, for 60 days. It's not yet clear if those efforts will bring relief for consumers. A lot of factors contribute to gas prices. Refineries buy crude oil in

advance, meaning some could be working with more expensive oil for a while, and it will take time for any new supply to trickle down to consumers. And while steep crude prices are a leading driver behind today's surge, US gas prices typically tick up a bit at this time of year. More drivers are hitting the road and trying to fuel up while they can, so there's higher demand.

Warming weather also brings a shift to summer blend fuel, which is more expensive to produce than winter blend. The US, which is a net oil exporter, hasn't seen as stark a shock as other parts of the world that rely more heavily on fuel imports from the Middle East, notably Asia. But

that doesn't mean America is immune to price spikes.

Oil is a globally-traded commodity. And most of what the US produces is light, sweet crude — but refineries on the East and West coasts are primarily designed to process heavier, sour product. As a result, the country also needs imports.

Escalating geopolitical conflicts have disrupted oil flows and contributed to a surge in gas prices in the past. The US average for regular gasoline climbed to its highest level of more than \$4 a gallon in June 2022, nearly four months after the Ukraine war began and world leaders imposed sanctions against Russia, a leading oil producer. (PTI)

West Asia conflict to impact GDP: EY

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India's real GDP growth for the next fiscal could erode by around 1 percentage point, while retail inflation could rise by about 1.5 percentage points from their baseline estimates if the Middle East conflict persists through the next fiscal, an EY report said.

The EY Economy Watch report said that several sectors, including employment-intensive sectors like textiles, paints, chemicals, fertilizers, cement and tires, could be directly impacted. Any reduction in employment or incomes in these sectors may further dampen aggregate demand. As a



result, both supply and demand conditions may be adversely affected by global oil market disturbances.

It said the Indian economy, which imports nearly 90 per cent of its crude oil require-

ments, is also highly dependent on imports of natural gas and fertilisers, and is particularly vulnerable to such external shocks, with the adverse effects likely to cascade across multiple sectors through

strong forward and backward linkages with crude oil and energy. The ongoing conflict in the Middle East has significantly disrupted global crude oil and energy markets by affecting supply, storage, transportation and prices. Even if the conflict is resolved in the near term, some of these disruptions may take considerable time to normalise, it said.

"If the impact persists throughout FY27, we estimate that India's real GDP growth could erode by around 1 percentage points, while CPI inflation could rise by approximately 1.5 percentage points from their baseline estimates of 7 per cent and 4 per cent respec-

tively," the EY Economy Watch report said. EY in its February report had projected India's GDP could be between 6.8 and 7.2 per cent in the 2026-27 fiscal.

In response, the Government of India may need to deploy a substantive countercyclical policy. It may also be prudent for the GoI to co-opt larger and more industrialised states into this countercyclical effort.

Additional provisions may be made to augment the Economic Stabilization Fund (ESF) introduced by the GoI in FY26, EY said. The government has already set up a '1-lakh crore ESF to act as a financial buffer against global headwinds.

I-T department notifies all 7 ITR forms

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Income Tax department has notified all income tax return forms for the assessment year (AY) 2026-27. While ITR forms 1-4, filed by small and medium taxpayers, were notified on March 30, ITR forms 2, 3, 5, 6 and 7, as well as ITR-U (for filing updated returns), were notified on Tuesday.

With the ITR (income tax return) notification, individuals, businesses and other entities can start filing I-T returns for the income earned in the financial year 2025-26. The last date for filing ITR for individuals and those who do not have to get their accounts audited is



July 31. ITR Form 1 (Sahaj) and ITR Form 4 (Sugam) are simpler forms that cater to a large number of small and medium taxpayers.

Sahaj can be filed by a resident individual having annual income up to '50 lakh and who receives income from salary, one house property, other sources (interest) and agricultural income up to '5,000 a year. Sugam can be filed by

individuals, Hindu Undivided Families (HUFs) and firms (other than Limited Liability Partnerships (LLPs)) having total annual income up to '50 lakh and income from business and profession. ITR-2 is filed by individuals and HUFs who do not have income from profits and gains in business or profession, but have income from capital gains.

ITR-3 is for individuals and HUFs earning income from a proprietary business or profession. ITR-5 is filed by firms and limited liability partnership and cooperative societies ITR-6 is filed by companies registered under Companies Act. ITR-7 is filed by trusts and charitable institutions.

Government notifies Finance Act 2026, changes in tax provisions



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Government has notified the Finance Act 2026, paving way for effecting changes in tax provisions.

This Act gives effect to financial proposals of the central government for 2026-27, a gazette notification dated March 30 issued by the Ministry of Law and Justice said. "The following Act of Parliament received the assent of the President on March 30, 2026 and is hereby published for general information," it said.

Last week, Parliament approved the Finance Bill 2026 with the Rajya Sabha returning it to the Lok Sabha with a voice vote, completing the budgetary exercise for the next fiscal year starting April 1. The Lok Sabha had passed the bill on March 25, along with 32 amendments.

The Rajya Sabha returned the bill after a brief discussion, and Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman replied to queries raised by members. The Union Budget 2026-27 envisages a total expenditure of

'53.47 lakh crore, an increase of 7.7 per cent over the current fiscal year ending March 31.

The total capital expenditure proposed for the next fiscal year is '12.2 lakh crore.

It proposes a gross tax revenue collection of '44.04 lakh crore and a gross borrowing of Rs 17.2 lakh crore.

The fiscal deficit for FY27 is projected at 4.3 per cent of GDP, lower than 4.4 per cent in the current fiscal.

As per the provisions of Finance Act, a flat 12 per cent surcharge will be levied on capital gains earned by individual or corporate shareholders by selling shares in the buyback offer of companies from April 1.

Imposing a flat 12 per cent surcharge on capital gains from buybacks for individual shareholders would significantly raise their effective tax cost, as a lower surcharge structure was applied earlier.

Currently, no surcharge is levied on taxable income up to '50 lakhs, while taxable income between '50 lakhs and '1 crore attracts a 10 per cent surcharge on capital gains from buybacks.

New I-T law, higher STT on F&O trade to kick in from today

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The new income tax law and other budgetary provisions, including higher Securities Transaction Tax (STT) on F&O trade and lower TCS on overseas tour packages and LRS remittances for medical and education purposes, will come into effect from April 1.

Also, the Budget announcement of a 20-year tax holiday up to 2047 to any foreign company that procures data centre services in India, and new safe harbour provisions with a higher threshold for software companies will come into effect from Wednesday, with the beginning of the 2026-27 fiscal. The Income-tax Act, 2025, will replace the Income-tax Act, 1961, with effect from April 1, 2026. The new Act aims to present the same tax policy in a more logical, accessible, and reader-friendly format.

The Income Tax department has said that its e-filing portal will facilitate compliance under both the old and new Income Tax Acts in the transition period, and all assessments, appeals, and other proceedings relating to earlier years will continue to be conducted under the old Act until their final resolution. Taxpayers filing returns for AY 2026-27 (pertaining to the period governed by the old Act) in July 2026 will do so using the forms prescribed under the

old Act. Advance tax payments for Tax Year 2026-27, commencing from June 2026, will be made in accordance with the new Act. The Income Tax Act, 2025, simplifies the tax timeline by doing away with the distinction between the assessment



year and the previous year, replacing it with a single "tax year" framework.

It also allows taxpayers to claim TDS refund even when ITRs are filed after deadlines, without any penal charges. Another major change in income tax that would come

into effect from April 1 is the Budget announcement of higher STT on F&O trade. STT on futures contracts will rise to 0.05 per cent from 0.02 per cent, while STT on options premiums and exercise of options will be hiked to 0.15 per cent from the present rate of 0.1 per cent and 0.125 per cent, respectively. The higher STT is aimed at curbing speculative bets being placed on shares in the F&O segment of equity markets and is intended to protect small investors from heavy losses in speculative trades. The number of unique individual investors trading in the equity derivatives (F&O) segment was 1.06 crore in FY25, which dropped to about 75.43 lakh in FY26

(up to December 30, 2025). As per a Sebi study titled 'Comparative study of growth in equity derivatives segment vis-a-vis cash market', individual investors incurred net losses of over '1.05 lakh crore in FY25.

The implementation of lower TCS on overseas tour packages and on remittances under the Liberalised Remittance Scheme (LRS) for medical and education purposes is aimed at helping the middle class.

TCS on overseas tour packages have been slashed to 2 per cent from 20 per cent, while on remittance for medical and education purpose, the rate would be 2 per cent, against 5 per cent currently.

Indian business delegation visits China after a five-year hiatus

KJM VARMA
■ Beijing

An Indian chambers of commerce delegation is currently visiting China to interact with their counterparts here, marking the first such visit after the five-year freeze in relations. A delegation of the Punjab, Haryana, Delhi, Chambers of Commerce and Industry (PHDCCI) is on a visit to Shanghai and China's Jiangsu province, one of the most industrialised areas of China, from March 29 to April 4.

This is the first Indian trade delegation to visit China after the two countries normalised bilateral relations last year, after over five years of hiatus following the military standoff



at Eastern Ladakh in 2020. The relations were on the course of normalisation after the meetings between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chinese President Xi Jinping in 2024 and 2025 on the sidelines of the BRICS and SCO summits.

The Indian Consulate General of Shanghai, Pratik

Mathur, on Tuesday hosted a Business Round Table between the PHDCCI Delegation and leading companies and financial institutions from Eastern China to explore opportunities for collaboration with Indian businesses. Welcoming the delegation, Mathur noted that

India continues to emerge as the world's fastest-growing major economy with one of the youngest demographics globally, creating immense opportunities for international partnerships and investments, a press release by the Consulate said.

During his address, Mathur emphasised India's expanding prospects in several sunrise sectors, including New and Renewable Energy, Electric Vehicles (EVs), connectivity and infrastructure development, as well as information and technology industries. These sectors, he said, offer significant potential for collaboration between Indian and global companies seeking sus-

tainable growth. The visit of the PHDCCI delegation was designed to build stronger connections between Indian businesses and industry counterparts in Eastern China, particularly in Shanghai, the country's commercial hub, as well as the rapidly growing provinces of Zhejiang and Jiangsu, the press release said.

The engagement aimed to encourage new partnerships, strengthen trade ties, and promote long-term cooperation between companies from both regions. In addition to industrial discussions, the visit also focused on fostering technology partnerships and facilitating business-to-business (B2B) meetings. (PTI)

IndiGo appoints William Walsh as new CEO



RAJESH KUMAR
■ New Delhi

IndiGo on Tuesday announced the appointment of former British Airways chief William Walsh, popularly known as Willie, as its new Chief Executive Officer (CEO). Walsh is succeeding Elbers who resigned from the airline on March 10.

The Board of InterGlobe Aviation Limited (IndiGo) on Tuesday appointed William Walsh as the Chief Executive Officer, subject to regulatory approvals. Mr Walsh's tenure at IATA comes to a close on the July 31, 2026, and he is expected to join no later than on the August 3, 2026, said IndiGo in an official statement.

Walsh, an airline industry veteran, is currently the Director General of the International Air Transport Association (IATA) and was formerly CEO of British Airways and IAG (International Airlines Group, a holding company which owns Aer Lingus, British Airways, Iberia, Level and Vueling).

China factory activity rebounds in March

CHAN HO-HIMAP
■ Hong Kong

China's factory activity expanded in March, ending two months of contraction, the government said Tuesday, but analysts say prolonged impacts of the Iran war could weigh on growth.

The official manufacturing purchasing managers index rose to 50.4 from 49 in February, the National Bureau of Statistics reported, beating economists' expectations and notching the strongest reading in a year. PMI is measured on a scale of 0 to 100 and a reading above 50 indicates expansion.

While the latest official data covered a period after the Iran war began on Feb. 28,



analysts say the impacts of surging energy costs have not yet been fully seen. "So far supply disruptions have not occurred in a material way," said Jacqueline Rong, Chief China Economist, BNP Paribas, a French bank.

A years-long property sector slump in China has also weighed on economic

growth and weakened domestic consumption and investment demand in China, the world's second-largest economy after the US. To help drive its economy, China has been reliant on growing exports, especially to regions such as Southeast Asia and Europe, which propelled its trade surplus last year to a

record \$1.2 trillion despite higher US tariffs.

China's export engine could hit headwinds as the Iran war drive up energy costs and disrupts supply chains, with most maritime traffic blocked from passing the Strait of Hormuz, through which roughly a fifth of the world's oil normally passes.

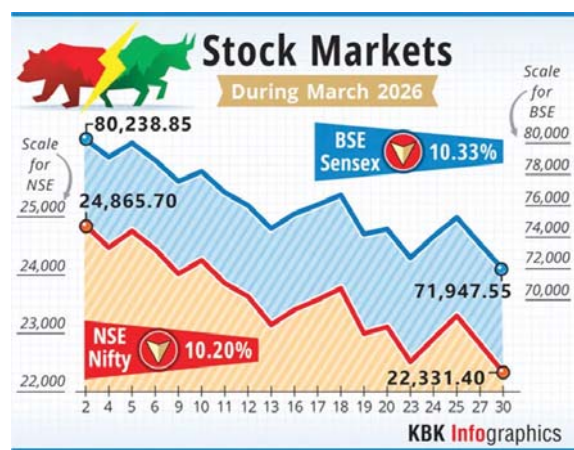
The extent of the impact will depend on how long the energy flows from the Middle East are cut off, said BNP Paribas' Rong. "If it is months, rather than weeks, then the supply disruptions, not just from oil, but also from the shortage of many chemical products - such as rare gases - would manifest itself in disrupting industrial production and services," she said. (AP)

Market outlook for FY27 remains optimistic, says Analysts

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The outlook for Indian markets in the next fiscal year remains structurally optimistic once geopolitical tensions subside and crude oil prices stabilise, analysts said, even as domestic equities ended FY26 on a bearish note, with Sensex plunging 7 per cent.

In 2025-26, the BSE benchmark plunged 5,467.37 points, or 7 per cent, and the NSE Nifty dropped 1,187.95 points, or 5 per cent. The year was dominated by global macro uncertainty, persistent geopolitical tensions, ele-



vated crude prices, and aggressive FII (Foreign Institutional Investors) out-

flows, which collectively capped upside momentum, an expert said.

FROM THE WORLD

PAKISTAN

Nine militants killed: Police

At least nine militants were killed in an operation by Pakistan's security forces after an attack on a Government school in northwestern Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, police said on Tuesday. The militants stormed Government High School Khwaja Mir Kalay in the Aka Khel area of Bara Tehsil, Khyber district, on Monday, in an apparent attempt to seize control of the building. During the attack, the militants removed the national flag and hoisted their own flag on the school building. Security forces responded swiftly, engaging the militants in a fierce gun battle. Following the exchange of fire, nine militants were killed, and the forces regained control of the school, reinstating the national flag atop the building. The militants had circulated a video on social media showing their control of the school and the raising of their flag, apparently as a propaganda effort. In the aftermath of the attack, security forces launched a large-scale search and clearance operation in the surrounding areas to track down any remaining assailants and their facilitators. The school has since been fully cleared, and the situation is reported to be under control.

Ex-Kathmandu CDO arrested over Gen Z protest crackdown

SHIRISH B PRADHAN

Kathmandu

Former chief district officer (CDO) of Kathmandu Chhabi Rijal was arrested on Tuesday for his alleged role in the crackdown of the Gen Z movement in September last year. Rijal, who was named in the list of high officials responsible for suppressing the Gen Z movement in which 76 people were killed, was arrested from his residence at Subidhanagar in Kathmandu, according to Nepal police. The development comes days after the arrest of former prime minister KP Sharma Oli and then home minister Ramesh Lekhak. (PTI)

Trump willing to end war without reopening Hormuz: WSJ reports

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

Washington

US President Donald Trump has told his aides that he's willing to end the military operation against Iran even if the Strait of Hormuz remains largely closed, leaving the campaign to reopen it for a later date, the Wall Street Journal (WSJ) reported, citing administration officials. In recent days, Trump and his aides assessed that a mission to pry open the chokepoint would push the conflict beyond his timeline of four to six weeks, the Daily said in a report. According to the report, Trump decided that the US should achieve its main goals of hobbling Iran's navy and its missile stocks and wind down current hostilities while pressuring Tehran diplomat-



ically to resume the free flow of trade. If that fails, Washington would press allies in Europe and the Gulf to take the lead on reopening the strait, the WSJ said, quoting officials. At a media briefing on Monday, White House Press Secretary Karoline Leavitt said the president and the

chief of the Pentagon have always stated a four to six-week estimated timeline for the military operation. "We're on day 30 today," she said. Leavitt also indicated that the Arab countries can be asked to share the burden of the military operation in Iran. "I think it's something the president would be quite

interested in. I won't get ahead of him on that but certainly it's an idea, something that I think you'll hear more from him on," she said to a question of whether countries such as Kuwait, the UAE and Saudi Arabia should pick up the tab for the Iran operation. Starting February 28, the US and Israel launched joint strikes against Iran, which in turn retaliated, spreading the war to the entire Gulf region. The Strait of Hormuz is a strategically important choke point for the world's energy supplies. The strait, a narrow shipping lane that connects the Persian Gulf with the Indian Ocean, remains effectively closed, bringing to a near halt the transit of hundreds of vessels per day, including container, dry bulk and liquid cargo ships.

Yemeni lawmaker sues US military veterans

JULIE WATSON

San Diego

A Yemeni lawmaker says in a lawsuit that US military veterans who worked for a private security firm were hired as mercenaries to kill him in 2015 on behalf of the United Arab Emirates as part of a campaign by the US ally that targeted political opponents. The lawsuit by Anssaf Ali Mayo in federal court in San Diego was unsealed last week, revealing details of the allegations against former executives and employees of Spear Operations Group, a private military contracting firm that incorporated in Delaware in 2015 but was dissolved in 2018. Many of the employees were former US special forces operators. Mayo, a member of Yemen's parliament, who is represented by the Centre for Justice and Accountability, accuses two military veterans and the founder of Spear Operations of carrying out war crimes, crimes against



humanity and an attempted extrajudicial killing. The complaint said the UAE paid the private military contractor USD 1.5 million per month, plus bonuses for successful killings in Yemen, including Mayo's. The scheme described in the lawsuit echoes a 2018 report by BuzzFeed News that US veterans were behind the attempt on his life. According to the complaint, Spear founder and CEO, Abraham Golan, an Israeli-

Hungarian dual citizen, recruited US military veterans, including former Navy SEAL Isaac Gilmore, who later became chief operating officer of Spear, and former US Army Special Forces member Dale Comstock. According to the complaint, the three men have admitted to their roles in the assassination campaign and the attempt on Mayo's life. "There was a targeted assassination program in Yemen," Golan confirmed to

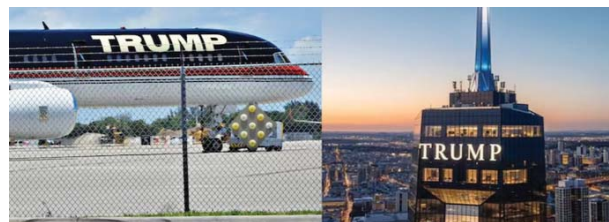
Buzzfeed. "I was running it. We did it. It was sanctioned by the UAE within the coalition." At the time, according to court documents, Golan and Gilmore lived in the San Diego area and held meetings about their plans there. Gilmore did not immediately respond to a voicemail message seeking comment. Comstock also did not respond to a message left on his professional website seeking comment. The Associated Press was not able to reach Golan. The UAE has said it has supported counterterrorism operations in Yemen but has denied targeting political opponents there. The Emirati foreign ministry and the Gulf nation's embassy in Washington did not immediately respond to a request for comment Monday about the lawsuit. Mayo does not live in the US but under the Alien Tort Statute, foreigners can sue in US federal court for violations of international law. (AP)

Airport cleared to be renamed after Trump

ASSOCIATED PRESS

Washington

A Florida airport was cleared to be renamed after President Donald Trump on Monday, hours before the president separately revealed plans for a Miami skyscraper planned to house his presidential library. Florida Gov. Ron DeSantis signed a bill allowing Palm Beach International Airport to be renamed the President Donald J Trump International Airport. The change is set to take place in July, formally rebranding the airport near Trump's Mar-a-Lago estate. Later Monday, Trump



posted a video to social media that appears to show digital renderings for his presidential library. Set to dramatic music, the video unveils a piercing tower along the Miami skyline emblazoned with the signature "Trump" lettering seen on his other towers. The video includes panning shots of the tower's exterior

and interior, with a presidential jet parked in the lobby alongside a gold escalator like the one Trump rode while launching his presidential campaign in 2015. Other shots show a giant ballroom like the one he's planning for the White House, a replica Oval Office, rooftop gardens and a large, gold statue of Trump.

A credit says the design comes from Bermello Ajamil, a Miami-based firm. Trump posted the video with no explanation beyond a link to a new

website for the library. The website says, "coming soon," with a link to donate money. The White House did not immediately respond to questions about the plans. Miami Dade College gave up a nearly 3-acre plot of downtown real estate as a gift for the future library. A judge in December dismissed a complaint challenging the gift on grounds that the college's board didn't give sufficient public notice. The site is valued at more than USD 67 million. Trump's son Eric previously said the library will be "one of the most beautiful buildings ever built" and "an icon on the Miami skyline." Since he returned to the White House, Trump has pressed to get his name on all manner of American institutions, from the US Institute of Peace and the Kennedy Centre performing arts venue to US currency. In Palm Beach, a stretch of road from the airport to Trump's estate was recently renamed Donald J Trump Boulevard.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Known to all that my client Smt. Kamla Devi owner of Property No. F-54B, Plot No.54 Area 50 Sq. Yds, Kharsa No. 7/20/1, Om Vihar Extn, F-Block, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi-110059, and My Client Purchased aforesaid property from Sh. Dev Raj vide notarized GPA, ATS and Will dated 03.03.2022 now My Client wants to sell aforesaid property. And It is informed that any deal with said documents by any person except my said client and said institution regarding said property, shall be deemed as null and void. If any person having any claim, right in said property then he may contact and handover the same and apprise his claim to undersigned within 15 days of this notice.

For AD REM LEGAL SOLUTION
Ch. No. 760, Dwarka Court, Sector-10, Dwarka, New Delhi-75, M:-9899013918

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that my client Anita is in process to purchase the Second Floor, east facing, area measuring 92.50 sq.yds built on property no.26, Kharsa no.51/2, Village Mandawali, Fazalpur, Ganesh Nagar, Shahdara Delhi-110082 m (availing loan from IFL Housing Finance Limited) from Ravinder Kumar Nagar having acquired by virtue of Conveyance Deed dated 16/11/2025 Doc 2025/5/11/1288 executed by PDI under PM UDARI. My client informed that her seller Ravinder Kumar is not having the below mentioned Documents pertaining to the said property and online FIR has already been lodged on dated 31/3/2026 in lieu of that.

1. Original GPA, ATS and WILL dated 21/9/2012 executed by Rama Rani Verma in favor of Bina Kumar

All persons having any claim against or in respect of the said Property, or any part thereof, by way of sale, exchange, mortgage (equitable/registered or otherwise), gift, trust, inheritance, family arrangement, maintenance, bequest, partnership, possession, lease, sublease, tenancy, license, lien, charge, pledge, easement or otherwise whatsoever, are hereby requested to notify the same in writing to us with supporting documentary evidence at the address mentioned below within 7 days from the date hereof, failing which the claim or claims, if any, of person or persons will be considered to have been waived and/or abandoned.

Kamali Kant Gupta (Advocate)
Unit No. FF-2, First floor, Mahalaxmi Metro Tower Sec-4, Vaidhali, Gzb., U.P., Mob. 9810063351

27-year-old Indian-origin man shot dead in Canada

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

Ottawa

A man, known to be of Indian origin, has been killed in Canada's Surrey in an incident of shooting allegedly related to organised crime, local media reported. The shooting incident was reported from a townhouse complex in Surrey's Sullivan Heights on Saturday night, in which a man was shot dead, Global News reported. The Integrated Homicide Investigation Team (IHIT) said in an update on Monday that the victim has been identified as 27-year-old Jasman Sekhon, CTV News reported. "Sekhon had previous interactions with the police and was believed to be involved in the drug trade. Early indications suggest this was a targeted incident related to organised crime,"



the report said, quoting the IHIT's statement. According to witnesses, Sekhon was first chased by a dark SUV after which two men stepped out of it and started shooting at him, the report said. Officials found Sekhon with gunshot wounds when they arrived and failed to revive him, it added. A burning vehicle was found nearby after the shooting incident, which police

say is the hallmark of gang killings. Officials are trying to confirm if the burning vehicle is related to the shooting incident. "Investigators are working diligently to determine the circumstances surrounding the homicide and identify all parties involved," the report quoted Sgt Freda Fong as saying. There have been four shootings in Surrey in the past 48 hours.

NASA begins countdown for moon launch on Wednesday



MARCIA DUNNAP

Cape Canaveral (Florida)

NASA began the countdown Monday for humanity's first launch to the moon in 53 years. The 32-story Space Launch System rocket is poised to blast off Wednesday evening with four astronauts. After a day in orbit around Earth, their Orion capsule will propel them to the moon and back. There are no stops, just a quick U-turn around the moon. The nearly 10-day flight will end with a splashdown in the Pacific. Managers said the rocket is doing well following the latest round of repairs. Forecasters said the weather should cooperate. NASA's Artemis II mission should have

soared in February, but was grounded by hydrogen fuel leaks. The leaks were fixed, but then a helium pressurization line became clogged, forcing a return to the hangar late last month. The rocket returned to the pad 1 1/2 weeks ago, and its US-Canadian crew arrived at the launch site on Friday. Unlike Apollo, which sent only men to the moon from 1968 through 1972, Artemis' debut crew includes a woman, person of colour and a non-US citizen. Artemis II's pilot Victor Glover said over the weekend that he wants young people to see them and think, "Girl power and that's awesome, and that young brown boys and girls can look at me and go Hey, he looks like me and he's doing what?" (AP)

Israel's Parliament passes death penalty bill targeting Palestinians

JULIA FRANKEL

Jerusalem

Israel's parliament on Monday passed a law approving the death penalty for Palestinians convicted of murdering Israelis, a measure that has been harshly condemned by the international community and rights groups as discriminatory and inhumane. The passage of the bill marked the culmination of a yearslong drive by the far-right to escalate punishment for Palestinians convicted of nationalistic offences against Israelis. Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu came to the Knesset to vote for the bill in person. The law makes the death penalty - by hanging - the default punishment for West Bank Palestinians convicted of nationalistic killings. It also gives Israeli courts the option of imposing the death penalty on Israeli citizens convicted on similar charges - language that legal experts say effectively confines those who can be sentenced to death to Palestinian citizens of Israel and excludes Jewish citizens. It will not apply retroactively to any prisoners Israel currently holds, including the Hamas-led militants who attacked the country on October 7, 2023, triggering the Israel-Hamas war in the Gaza Strip. After the final 62-48 vote in favour, lawmakers erupted into cheers and stood up in jubilation. Netanyahu, who remained in his seat, did not immediately react or speak. Israel's firebrand minister of national security, Itamar Ben-Gvir, who spearheaded the push for the legislation, brandished a bottle in celebration.



Far-right lawmaker Limor Son Har-Melech, one of the bill's original sponsors whose first husband was killed in a Palestinian militant attack in the West Bank, smiled through tears. The law will face legal challenges: The legislation, which says it will take effect in 30 days, is certain to face legal challenges that may stall its implementation. Minutes after the bill passed, the Association of Civil Rights in Israel said it had already petitioned Israel's highest court to challenge the law. It called the legislation "discriminatory by design" and said the parliament had enacted it "without legal authority" over West Bank Palestinians, who are not Israeli citizens. Amichai Cohen, a senior fellow at the Israel Democracy Institute's Centre for Democratic Values and Institutions, said that under international law, Israel's parliament should not be legislating in the West Bank, which is not sovereign Israeli territory. (AP)

कायालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, चतुर्थ वृत्त,

लोक निर्माण विभाग, रुद्रपुर (ऊधमसिंह नगर)

फोन: 05944-240921 ईमेल: sepwdusn@gmail.com

पत्रांक : 683 / 23 एम-04 / 2026

दिनांक : 31 / 03 / 2026

राष्ट्रीय प्रतिस्पर्धात्मक ई-निविदा (e-tendering)

महामहिम राज्यपाल उत्तराखण्ड की ओर से अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, चतुर्थ वृत्त, लोकनिविदे रुद्रपुर (ऊधम सिंह नगर) द्वारा निम्नलिखित कार्यो हेतु ई-टेंडरिंग द्वारा टू-बिड सिस्टम के अन्तर्गत निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है। निविदा से सम्बन्धित सभी सूचनायें वेबसाइट <http://www.uktenders.gov.in> पर दिनांक 08.04.2026 से उपलब्ध रहेगी।

क्र. सं.	कार्य का नाम	घरोहर धनराशि (लाख में)	निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य (रु में)	निविदा की वैधता (दिवस)	कार्य पूर्ण करने का समय (माह में)	ठेकेदार की श्रेणी
1	2	3	4	5	6	7
1	मां०मु० घो० संख्या 333/2019 के अन्तर्गत जनपद ऊधमसिंह नगर के विधानसभा क्षेत्र खटीमा के अन्तर्गत राज्य मार्ग-70 सत्रहमील से नानकसागर प्रभाग का 1.5 लेन में उच्चीकरण किए जाने का कार्य। चौनेज (40.275 से 53.875)	66.63	5000.00 +18% G.S.T	120 दिन	18 माह	भारत सरकार / किसी भी राज्य सरकार के विभाग एवं उपक्रम में सेतु कार्य हेतु श्रेणी A एवं उच्चतर में पंजीकृत
2	मा० मुखमन्त्री घोषणा संख्या 333/2019 के अन्तर्गत जनपद ऊधमसिंह नगर के विधानसभा क्षेत्र खटीमा के अन्तर्गत (राज्य मार्ग-70) बिगराबाग से चकरपुर तक के भाग को उच्चीकृत कर एक लेन से डेढ़ लेन में परिवर्तन किये जाने का कार्य।	15.50	5000.00 +18% G.S.T	120 दिन	12 माह	भारत सरकार / किसी भी राज्य सरकार के विभाग एवं उपक्रम में सेतु कार्य हेतु श्रेणी A एवं उच्चतर में पंजीकृत
3	राज्य योजना के अन्तर्गत सुखापुल लोहिया हेड सहीद द्वार से कालापुल एस० एस० बी० कैंप टेलफाल कॉलोनी बाईसपुल मार्ग नारायणनगर बंगाली का पुर्ननिर्माण कार्य (टेलफाल नारायणनगर बंगाली कॉलोनी बाईसपुल)	3.40	5000.00 +18% G.S.T	120 दिन	12 माह	मार्ग कार्य हेतु श्रेणी C एवं उच्चतर में पंजीकृत

अधीक्षण अभियन्ता

PUBLIC NOTICE

To, All State Secretaries Hindustan Scouts and Guides Association

Subject: Notice of Forthcoming Elections (2026-2029) and Resumption of Scouting Activities

Dear Sir/Madam,

In accordance with the registered Bye-Laws of the Hindustan Scouts and Guides Association, notice is hereby given for the conduct of elections for the State Council/Executive Committees across all functional states.

To ensure the democratic integrity and organizational growth of our movement, all State Chapters are directed to initiate the following actions immediately:

1. Conduct of Elections Elections must be held in strict adherence to the provisions laid out in the Association's Constitution and Bye-Laws. This includes:

• Verification of Electoral College: Ensuring all eligible voting members are cleared and listed.

• Appointment of Returning Officers: Designating neutral observers to oversee the nomination and polling process.

• Transparency: Maintaining a clear record of proceedings to be submitted to the National Headquarters upon completion.

2. Resumption of Scouting Activities Parallel to the electoral process, it is imperative that scouting activities resume with full vigor to benefit our youth members. State units are encouraged to:

• Organize Camps, Rallies, and Training Programs at the district and state levels.

• Update membership registrations and ensure scout masters/guides captains are briefed on the yearly calendar.

• Focus on community service projects that align with the core values of the scouting movement.

Key Timelines The election process should be initiated within 30 days of this notice. A detailed schedule regarding the filing of nominations and the date of polling must be circulated to all concerned members within your respective jurisdictions.

We look forward to your cooperation in strengthening the association and fostering the spirit of scouting across the nation.

By Order, For Hindustan Scouts and Guides Association Mr. Rajesh Kumar (National Secretary)

Three ships crossed Hormuz, says China



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Beijing

China on Tuesday said three of its ships carrying oil supplies have passed through the Strait of Hormuz and thanked “relevant parties” for facilitation and coordination.

“After coordination with relevant parties, three Chinese ships recently transited the Strait of Hormuz. We express appreciation for the assistance of relevant parties”, Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson Mao Ning told a media briefing here without naming Iran, which is currently controlling the movement of oil shipments from the Gulf crossing the Strait.

Iran is demanding international recognition of its sovereignty over the Strait of Hormuz.

The Strait of Hormuz and waters nearby are an important route for international goods and energy trade. China calls for an immediate end to hostilities to restore peace and stability in the

Gulf, Mao said. This is the first time China, a large importer of Iranian oil for years despite US sanctions, spoke of its ships crossing the Strait of Hormuz amid reports that Iran is permitting the Chinese ships to cross the Strait in view of the close strategic ties.

Mao also said the Middle East war will figure in the meeting between Pakistan Deputy Prime Minister Ishaq Dar and Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi.

Dar, who is also the Foreign Minister, is travelling to China on Tuesday. He is expected to brief Wang on the discussions held during the meeting between the Foreign Ministers of Türkiye, Egypt and Saudi Arabia to promote talks between the US and Iran to end the ongoing conflict. On Dar’s visit, Mao said China and Pakistan are all-weather strategic cooperative partners of mutual trust and mutual support.

The two countries share similar positions and maintain close communication on

major international and regional issues, she said.

It’s believed that the two foreign ministers will step up strategic communication and coordination on the situation in Iran and other international and regional issues of mutual interest, jointly call for peace and a just position, and make new efforts to help end the conflict and bring about peace and stability in the region, she said.

Ever since the US and Israel attacked Iran, China has been calling on all countries to immediately stop military operations. China has also been calling for keeping the Strait of Hormuz open, as its closure resulted in widespread disruption of fuel supplies.

While condemning the attacks on Iran, China is also preparing for US President Donald Trump’s visit scheduled for May 14-15, during which expectations are high to finalise a trade deal between the two countries.

Mongolia names new PM in bid to end legislative deadlock

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Ulaanbaatar (Mongolia)

Mongolia’s parliament has confirmed Uchral Nyam-Osor as the third prime minister in a year in a bid to end a deadlock in the legislature at a time of mounting economic pressures for the landlocked, resource-dependent country.

Uchral called for political unity, saying internal disputes have compounded external challenges.

“As others unite to confront crises, we cannot afford political infighting that weakens our economy,” he told lawmakers. A total of 107 of the body’s 126 lawmakers voted Monday night, with 88 supporting Uchral — or 82.2 per cent — clearing the way for

the 39-year-old leader to take office. Uchral is a former minister of digital development and communications, where he promoted transparency reforms and digital governance initiatives. Before entering politics, Uchral got public attention as a hip-hop artist under the stage name “Timon.”

He has positioned himself as a reform-minded leader focused on modernising Mongolia’s regulatory environment, including streamlining the permitting systems inherited from the country’s Soviet-era.

Mongolia transitioned to democracy in 1990 after decades of one-party Communist rule.

His appointment comes amid renewed concern



among foreign investors over Mongolia’s political instability, frequent policy changes and reputation for corruption and regulatory unpredictability.

Uchral was seen as a compromise between factions in

the Mongolian People’s Party loyal to the president and others loyal to a former prime minister, Oyun-Erdene Luvsannamsrai.

A boycott by the opposition Democratic Party and the infighting in the ruling party

had left the parliament without the required number of members to hold votes in the session that began about two weeks ago.

Outgoing Prime Minister Zandanshatar Gombojav, who had taken office nine months ago, submitted his resignation Friday to resolve the crisis. He was also under pressure because one of his senior ministers faced corruption allegations.

Zandanshatar, who is close to the president, had replaced Oyun-Erdene, who was prime minister for four years before resigning last June after losing a vote of confidence in parliament. All three prime ministers are from the Mongolian People’s Party.

4 killed in China highway tunnel blast

KJM VARMA ■ Beijing

Four people were killed and nine others sustained injuries following an explosion at a highway tunnel under construction in southwest China’s Chongqing Municipality, local officials said on Tuesday.

The blast occurred on Monday afternoon at a construction site for a section of the national highway connecting Hubei and Sichuan provinces, according to the Wanzhou District transport commission.

Initial reports indicated that one person was missing and 12 others were wounded. By midnight on Tuesday, rescuers recovered the body of the missing indi-



vidual. Three of the injured later succumbed to their injuries despite receiving medical treatment, the state-run Xinhua news agency reported.

Preliminary findings

suggest the explosion may have been triggered by flammable gas. Authorities have cordoned off the site and an investigation into the cause of the accident is underway. (PTI)

King Charles III to undertake state visit to US, Bermuda

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ London

King Charles III will undertake a state visit to the United States in late April to celebrate the 250th anniversary of American Independence and to mark the close ties that exist between the two nations, Buckingham Palace said on Tuesday.

The visit follows US President Donald Trump’s state visit to the UK in September. That event was a glittering occasion featuring dazzling tiaras, brass bands and a sumptuous banquet served on 200-year-old silver. Such spectacles are meant to bolster ties between nations, particularly in difficult times.



Trump is known to be very fond of the royal family, but has had little patience with British Prime Minister Keir Starmer, who has offered only defensive support for his longtime ally in the Iran war.

Charles has visited the US 19 times, but it will be his first state visit to the country. His mother, Queen Elizabeth II, undertook four state visits to the US

Man held for attack on Russian centre in Prague

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Prague

Czech police said Tuesday that they have arrested a foreign national who claimed responsibility for using Molotov cocktails to attack a Russian cultural centre in Prague last week.

They said the male suspect turned himself in on Monday and that he acknowledged planning the attack since last summer on the Russian House, which is funded by the Russian state but doesn’t have diplomatic status. Police did not name the man’s nationality or



give any other details. The incident in the Czech capital took place late Thursday. A photo showed a broken window while two windows and a wall of the building were partly covered with smoke. The building did not catch fire, however.

The centre said it organises cultural, educational and scientific programmes and offers Russian language courses.

Its director, Igor Girenko, told the Russian state news agency Tass that six Molotov cocktails were thrown at the building on Thursday and that three of them did not explode.

Russian Foreign Ministry spokeswoman Maria Zakharova called it “a barbaric act,” while the Russian embassy in Prague asked the Czech authorities to boost security of Russian institutions and its employees in the country.

Japan deploys its first long-range missiles at southwestern army camp

MARI YAMAGUCHI ■ Tokyo

Japan’s first long-range missile was deployed at a southwestern army camp, officials said Tuesday, as the country pushes to bolster its offensive capabilities.

The upgraded Type-12 land-to-ship missiles, developed and produced by Japan’s Mitsubishi Heavy Industries, became operational at Camp Kengun in Kumamoto prefecture.

“As Japan faces the most severe and complex security environment in the postwar era ... it is an extremely important capability to strengthen

Japan’s deterrence and responsiveness,” Defence Minister Shinjiro Koizumi told reporters. “It demonstrates Japan’s firm determination and capability to defend itself.”

The upgraded Type-12 missile has a range of about 1,000 kilometres (620 miles), a significant extension from the 200-kilometre (125-mile) range of the original that would allow it to reach mainland China.

The deployment of the long-range missile gives Japan a “standoff” capability, meaning it can strike enemy missile bases from afar, marking a break from the self-defense



only policy the country long followed under its pacifist constitution.

Residents opposing the deployment near the residential area staged protests

systems to protect southwestern islands: Also Tuesday, a hypersonic glide vehicle, a new weapons system designed for island defense, was deployed to Camp Fuji in the Shizuoka prefecture, west of Tokyo. Additional deployment of the upgraded Type-12 missiles and HGVs at other locations in Japan, including Hokkaido in the north and Miyazaki in the south, are planned by March 2028.

Japan also plans to deploy US-made, 1,600-kilometer (990-mile)-range Tomahawk cruise missiles on Japanese destroyer JS Chokai later this year, and eventually on seven

other destroyers.

Takaichi boosts defence spending to counter China: Japan considers China its main regional security threat and has fortified the country’s southwestern islands near the East China Sea in recent years.

Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi’s Cabinet in December approved a record defence budget plan exceeding 9 trillion yen (\$58 billion) for the fiscal year beginning April and aims to fortify its strike-back capability and coastal defence with cruise missiles and unmanned arsenals.

Japan last June spotted two Chinese aircraft carriers almost simultaneously operating near Japanese remote islands in the Pacific for the first time, sparking Tokyo’s concern about Beijing’s military activity stretching far beyond its borders.

The defence minister last week announced the establishment of a new office dedicated to studying China’s Pacific activity. Tensions have escalated further since Takaichi’s statement in November that any Chinese military action against Taiwan could be grounds for a Japanese military response. (AP)

European diplomats steer attention to Ukraine with visit on Russian atrocities anniversary

LORNE COOK ■ Kyiv

European foreign ministers visited Ukraine on Tuesday to mark the fourth anniversary of atrocities committed in a town near Kyiv by Russia’s invading forces.

With US-led efforts to end the war on hold and Washington’s attention gripped by the conflict in the Middle East, European governments are keen to keep a spotlight on the continent’s biggest land war in decades, now in its fifth year.

A group of 12 European foreign ministers, as well as numerous lower-ranking officials, arrived by train in Kyiv, where they were welcomed by Ukrainian Foreign Minister Andrii Sybiha, who noted the “grim anniversary” of the shocking atrocities in Bucha.

Russian troops quickly



occupied the town after invading Ukraine on February 24, 2022. They stayed for about a month. When Ukrainian troops retook Bucha they found more than 400 bodies left by Russia’s cleansing operation.

“Such a strong European presence (in Ukraine) on this

day demonstrates that justice for this and other Russian atrocities is inevitable,” Sybiha said in a post on X. “Comprehensive accountability for Russian crimes is vital to restore justice in Europe.”

At the Church of Saint Andrew in Bucha, after viewing dozens of graphic

photographs and a video display of the massacres with his EU counterparts, Polish Foreign Minister Radek Sikorski was grim.

“Anybody who claims that (Russian President) Vladimir Putin is not a war criminal should come and see for themselves,” Sikorski told The Associated Press.

Authorities say that many of the victims were gunned down in the street. Some had their hands tied behind their backs, and others showed signs of torture or rape.

The United Nations has documented more than 70 summary executions.

Part of Tuesday’s meeting between the EU officials and their Ukrainian counterparts was to focus on reassuring Kyiv of continued European efforts to hold Russia to account for its invasion. (PTI)

Wolf bites woman in shopping area in Germany’s 2nd-biggest city

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Berlin

A wolf bit a woman in a shopping area in Hamburg before it was pulled out of a lake in Germany’s second-biggest city, authorities said, in what is believed to be the first such attack since wolves returned to the country in 1998.

The fire service said that the woman was taken to a Hamburg hospital after the unusual encounter on Monday evening, German news agency DPA reported.

There was no immediate information on her condition on Tuesday, and police didn’t detail where she was bitten. It also wasn’t clear what led to the attack.

The attack took place in a shopping area near the Altona station, west of the city centre. Late on Monday evening, police said, officers hauled the wolf out of



the Binnenalster lake in downtown Hamburg following calls alerting them to a sighting of the animal there and in other locations. Local media reported that it was taken to an enclosure on the outskirts of the city.

Officials believe it’s likely that the wolf involved was the same one that was sighted in Blankenese, an

outer suburb of the city, over the weekend. Experts believe that the animal is a young wolf searching for a territory of its own that accidentally wandered into the city. Hamburg’s regional government noted that wolves generally avoid contact with people and dogs, and the unusual urban environment would be very stressful.

Social media giants not complying with under-16s ban, says Australia

ROD MCGUIRK ■ Melbourne

Australia’s online safety watchdog said on Tuesday that it was considering court action against Facebook, Instagram, Snapchat, TikTok and YouTube alleging they are not doing enough to keep Australian children younger than 16 off their platforms.

Experts say the Australian courts could decide what steps the platforms can reasonably be expected to take under the laws that took effect on Dec. 10 banning young children from holding accounts.

eSafety Commissioner Julie Inman Grant on Tuesday released her first compliance report since those laws took effect demanding 10 plat-

forms remove all Australian account-holders younger than 16.

While 5 million Australian accounts had been deactivated, a substantial number of Australian children continued to retain accounts, create new accounts and pass platforms’ age assurance systems, the report said.

Inman Grant said in a statement her office had “significant concerns about the compliance” of half of those 10 platforms. Her office was gathering evidence against the five that they had not taken “reasonable steps” to prevent young children holding accounts.

Courts could order fines of up to 49.5 million



Australian dollars (\$33 million) for systemic failures to comply. eSafety would decide on whether to initiate court action against any platform by midyear.

Age-restricted platforms that aren’t under investigation are Reddit, X, Kick, Threads and Twitch.

Communications Minister Anika Wells said the five crit-

icized platforms were deliberately not complying with Australian law.

“Social media platforms are choosing to do the absolute bare minimum

because they want these laws to fail,” Wells told reporters.

“This is the world-leading law. We’re the first in the world to do it. Of course they don’t want these laws to work because they want that to be a chilling effect on the dozen countries that have come out since December 10 to follow Australia’s step,” she added.

eSafety had identified “poor practices” such as platforms allowing unlimited attempts for a user to pass their age assurance methods and prompting the user to try to pass the age assurance method even after they declared themselves underage. Meta, which owns Facebook and Instagram, told

The Associated Press it was committed to complying with Australia’s social media ban.

“We’ve also been clear that accurately determining age online is a challenge for the whole industry,” the statement said.

Snap Inc. said it has locked 450,000 accounts in compliance with the law and continued to lock more every day.

“Snapchat remains fully committed to implementing reasonable steps under the legislation and supporting its underlying goal of improving online safety for young Australians,” a Snap statement said.

TikTok declined to comment on Tuesday and Alphabet Inc., which owns

YouTube and Google, did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

Lisa Given, an information sciences expert at RMIT University in Melbourne, said she expected the courts will decide whether platforms have taken “reasonable steps” to exclude young children.

“If a tech company has said: look, we put in age assurance, we’ve done all these steps. That’s reasonable. Even though the aged assurance technologies are flawed, whose fault is that? Should they be held accountable for a piece of technology that is not 100 per cent and likely not going to be 100 per cent foolproof any time soon?” Given said. (AP)

PROSPECT

SBI MUTUAL FUND FILES DRAFT PAPERS WITH SEBI FOR IPO



SBI Mutual Fund, the country's largest fund house, on Thursday filed preliminary papers with capital markets regulator SEBI to raise funds through an Initial Public Offering (IPO). The proposed maiden public offering is entirely an Offer For Sale (OFS) of up to 20.37 crore equity shares, with no fresh issue component, according to the draft red herring prospectus (DRHP). The offering will see promoters, State Bank of India (SBI) and Amundi India Holding, pare their stakes. SBI Funds Management Ltd is a joint venture between SBI and Paris-based Amundi, holding 61.98 per cent and 36.40 per cent stake, respectively. The company is the country's largest asset management firm, with a quarterly average assets under management (QAAUM) of nearly ₹12.5 lakh crore as of December 2025.

INDIAN ARMY NEUTRALISES WW II ERA UXBS IN ASSAM



Based on inputs from the civil administration, unexploded ordnance comprising a World War II-era General Purpose bomb and an incendiary bomb was reported at Ledo, Burma Camp, Lekhapani in Assam. The munitions were discovered by a civilian while digging a pit, posing a serious threat to life and property. On March 31, 2026, the Red Shield Division of the Indian Army promptly mobilised a Bomb Disposal Team to the site. Civilians were immediately evacuated from the vicinity, and a secure perimeter was established, ensuring strict adherence to safety protocols. The unexploded bombs were carefully secured and transported to a designated safe location away from habitation. They were subsequently neutralised through a controlled operation, eliminating all risk without any collateral damage.

PMML to showcase rare historic documents in new exhibition

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

The Prime Minister's Museum and Library (PMML) will open a landmark exhibition titled "The Archives of PMML" on April 1, 2026 at Teen Murti Bhawan. The exhibition will be inaugurated by Nripendra Misra, Chairman of the Executive Council, Prime Minister's Museum & Library. In a first-of-its-kind initiative, the showcase will present a carefully curated selection of historically significant documents drawn from the institution's vast and unique archival repository. The exhibition will be open to the public from 1 to 14 April, between 10 am and 5 pm, at the PMML Back Foyer, PMS-1, Teen Murti Bhawan. Among the highlights are Mahatma Gandhi's 1932 letter to Bapsybanoo Pavry reflect-



Prime Minister's Museum & Library

ing on spiritual unity, the original handwritten draft of Jawaharlal Nehru's iconic "Tryst with Destiny" speech from 1947, and a series of letters exchanged between Atal Bihari Vajpayee,

Jayaprakash Narayan, and NM Ghatate during the Emergency years (1975-1976). The exhibition will also feature correspondence from former Prime Minister Manmohan Singh to Anna

Hazare in 2012, offering a glimpse into more recent political discourse. Housing over 25 million documents across more than 1,300 individual and institutional collections.

17 insurgents nabbed, arms and explosives seized in Manipur

TONY DAS

Imphal

In a massive crackdown on insurgent activities, the Indian Army and Assam Rifles, operating under the Spear Corps, in coordination with the Manipur Police, apprehended 17 cadres from various proscribed groups and recovered a significant cache of arms and explosives during a week-long series of operations across the State.

The intelligence-driven operations, conducted between March 22 and March 28, spanned the districts of Imphal East, Imphal West, Bishnupur, Chandel, Kangpokpi, Churachandpur, and Tengnoupal.

The week began with the apprehension of a KYKL cadre in Nambol Sabal Leikai by the Assam Rifles and Bishnupur Police Commandos on March 22. Simultaneously, a PREPAK (PRO) member was nabbed in the Singjamei area of Imphal West. The most significant haul occurred along the Indo-



Myanmar Border in Tengnoupal, where the Assam Rifles intercepted 10 PREPAK (RA) cadres. On March 23, security forces apprehended a KCP Apunba cadre in Chana village and a Kangleipak Communist Party (Nongdrenkhomba) member in the Sawombung area. Later in the week, on March 27, a PLA cadre and two others belonging to the KYKL and KCP were apprehended near Border Pillars 73 and 74 in the Chalon area. Beyond the arrests, the joint teams made substantial recoveries of "war-like stores" intended for disruptive activities. On March 25,

security forces recovered a carbine, two pistols, four magazines, five single-barrel rifles, and two improvised mortars from the area between Tingkhai Khullen and Nepali Khutti in the Kangpokpi District. The momentum continued on March 26 in Churachandpur, where operations in Loilamkot yielded two single-barrel rifles, three bombs, an improvised Explosive Device (IED), two 'pompies', and three grenades. In a final swoop on March 28 at Yangoubung Village in Chandel District, the joint team seized six pistols with magazines, a single-barrel rifle, 15 IEDs, and two radio sets.

Make water conservation a mass movement, says Sri Sri Ravi Shankar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

Bengaluru

At a ceremony organised by sarkaritel.com at the Vishalakshi Mantap within The Art of Living International Center, 36 "Water Warriors" were felicitated for their outstanding contributions to water conservation. On this occasion, Gurudev Sri Sri Ravi Shankar honoured all the Water Warriors by presenting them with

trophies, shawls, and certificates. In his address, he stated that devotion to water constitutes true service and that fostering awareness regarding water conservation within society is the greatest necessity of the present times. Expressing concern over environmental challenges, he noted that today, water, air, and the earth itself are all under the grip of pollution, thereby posing a grave crisis to humanity.



Subharti University students shine at Lakmé Fashion Week

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

Mumbai

Faculty members and students from the Department of Fashion & Textile Design, under the Faculty of Fine Arts at Swami Vivekanand Subharti University, Meerut, participated in the prestigious Lakmé Fashion Week & FDCI 2026 held at the Jio World Convention Centre in Mumbai.

Four B. Design 3rd year students — Kirti, Muskan Singh, Prenika, and Priya Yadav — were selected as volunteers and served as Event Assistants. They actively contributed to backstage coordination, show management, and overall event operations. Working alongside the teams of Lakmé Fashion Week and FDCI, they assisted in shows featuring renowned designers such as Rahul Mishra, Amit Aggarwal, Ritu Kumar, Ada Malik, Abraham & Thakore,



and Bhumika Sharma, gaining valuable insights into industry practices. The academic visit was led by Dr Neha Singh, Head of the Department, who accompanied the students and represented the university at this esteemed national platform. Dean of the Faculty of Fine Arts, Professor (Dr) Pintu Mishra, stated that the event

not only provides new direction to the fashion industry but also inspires young minds to pursue their dreams. The Chief Executive Officer of the university, Professor (Dr) Shalya Raj, remarked that this grand event held at the Jio World Convention Centre, Mumbai, has demonstrated that Subharti Fashion is establishing a strong identity at the global level.

DAILY SUDOKU

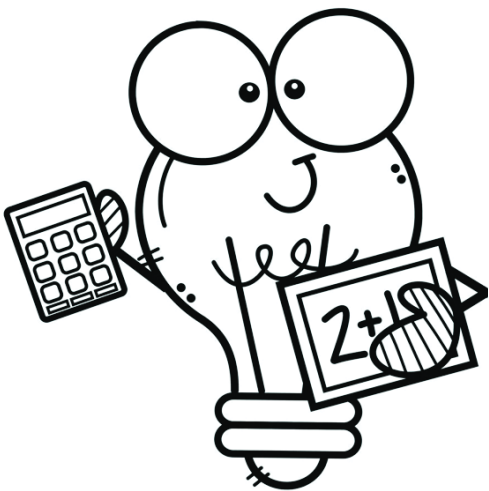
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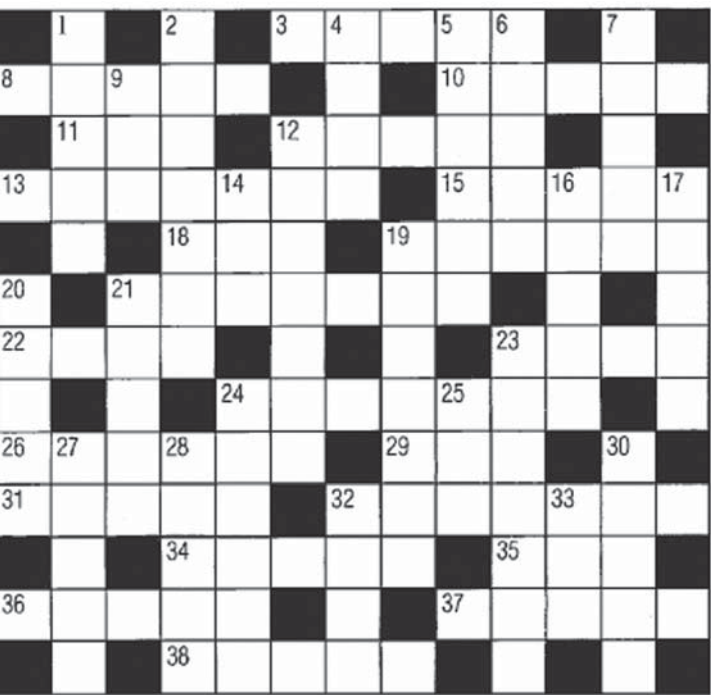
DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT !

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction-no maths involved.



DOUBLE CROSSWORD
WEDNESDAY | APRIL 1, 2026



ACROSS

- 3 Where, formerly, putting the finish before the start led to anger! (5)
8 Something to do with interest (5)
10 She's of some help to a space visitant (5)
11 Started the fire and left it (3)
12 Show how everyone gets a letter (5)
13 When it's cool out, run! (7)
15 Tries to take a girl around central Tooting (5)
18 Have polo ponies such ears? (3)
19 Because established at Epping? (6)
21 Half the side cried wildly for a golden goal! (7)

DOWN

- 1 Fruit of some long endeavours (5)
2 In major contests, let's bat cannily (7)
4 One of the first men to have a unit (4)
5 He does things in religiously correct order (6)
6 Maybe three can put you to sleep (5)
7 Short men (5)
9 From the pine, it's not a needle (3)
12 Shifty CIA plot of current interest (7)
14 A fancied flier (3)
16 They swim in waters around the Docklands centre (5)
17 Put on, dramatically (5)
19 It's used in flight (by the RAF out

- 22 Those broken up mostly for scrap? (4)
23 Beat at golf, maybe? (4)
24 Playthings of a spoilt starlet? (7)
26 Of the people making a bad start in a test (6)
29 Father's girl (3)
31 Such boys aren't slow (5)
32 Encourage to give attention to a broken net (7)
34 One presenting a soldier with a piece of silver (5)
35 Whence tea may run freely (3)
36 Fishy means of measuring? (5)
37 See "38"
38 and 37 Being right in a new role, had he to fly north again? (5,5)

- East? (7)
20 That great explorer (5)
21 It carries water in many thousands of drops (5)
23 Rod's joint (7)
24 Weapon used by gunners at a landing place (6)
25 Part of an arable area (3)
27 It swims in an arch around a circle (5)
28 Instrument forming a bulge (5)
30 In short, she has very little money (5)
32 Only a brave man will give her a ring(4)
33 It means a shot at goal (3)

Grassroots push under SVEEP to strengthen democracy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

Guwahati

Democracy thrives when every voice is heard. In a vibrant democracy, every vote counts and every voice matters. Guided by this principle, the Chief Electoral Officer, Assam, through the SVEEP programme, is leading impactful initiatives aimed at empowering voters, enhancing awareness, and encouraging wholehearted participation in the General Election to the Assam Legislative Assembly, 2026.

To strengthen participatory democracy, all DEOs of Assam, under the leadership of CEO, Assam, Anurag Goel, are driving dynamic and people-centric campaigns to ensure that no voter is left behind. Through innovative outreach and grassroots engagement, Assam is gearing up to celebrate the festival of democracy with greater participation than ever before.

The Office of the Chief Electoral Officer, Assam, continues to spearhead innovative initiatives to enhance voter awareness and participation. With a vision to make the election truly inclusive and partic-



ipative, an array of targeted interventions are being undertaken to inspire every eligible citizen to be a part of the great festival of democracy. As part of these efforts, various programmes such as street plays, drawing competitions, rangoli competitions, slogan writing competitions, digital poster-making competitions, wall writing, news presentation competitions, workshops, and other creative awareness activities are being conducted. In addition, to attract and engage voters, several districts have introduced appealing mascots,

while in some districts, popular personalities have been roped in as icons for voter awareness campaigns. Rakesh Bonik, renowned paracyclist and the State icon, is creating awareness amongst the voters across the State.

In a proactive effort to enhance voter participation and strengthen democratic engagement, the District Administration of Tamulpur, in collaboration with the SVEEP Cell, launched the "Adopt a Polling Station (PS) Campaign" across selected polling stations in the district.

DVK Foundation launches scholarship programme for EWS students at BGIS Vrindavan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

Vrindavan (Uttar Pradesh)

The DVK Foundation has introduced a dedicated scholarship programme for students from Economically Weaker Sections (EWS) at Bhaktivedanta Gurukula and International School (BGIS), Vrindavan.

The initiative, formalised through a recently signed MoU between the foundation and the institution, seeks to support meritorious students by providing financial assistance, study



materials and incentives for academic excellence. BGIS, ranked among the top boarding schools in Uttar Pradesh, will serve as the host institution for this initiative.

Under the programme, selected candidates, designat-

ed as DV Kapur Scholars, will receive comprehensive support, including study materials, uniforms, laptops and awards to aid their educational journey.

The scholarship also features an Annual Merit Award of up to ₹20,000 for students of Classes VIII, IX and XI, subject to school recommendation and foundation approval. Introduced from the academic session 2025-26, the scheme will continue until the students complete their schooling.

BRIEFLY

World Cup-bound Ghana fires coach Otto Addo



Otto Addo has been released from his contract as head soccer coach of Ghana, just 2 1-2 months before the team plays its first match at the World Cup.

"The Ghana Football Association (GFA) have parted ways with the head coach of the senior men's national team (Black Stars), Otto Addo effective immediately," it said in a statement Monday on its website. It gave no further details on a replacement for Addo or the reasons for the termination. The firing came after a 2-1 loss to Germany in Stuttgart on Monday. Ghana also lost 5-1 in Austria last Friday and has lost four friendlies in a row. Addo was on his second spell as coach of the team after Borussia Dortmund agreed to release him from his role in talent development at the end of the season in March 2024. Addo already coached Ghana on an interim basis for much of 2022, including at the World Cup in Qatar, when Ghana beat South Korea but was still eliminated in the group stage.

Undav makes his WC case for Germany with a winning goal



Deniz Undav turned up the pressure on Germany coach Julian Nagelsmann to select him for the World Cup after he scored the 2-1 winner against Ghana to back up strong club form. Undav hadn't played for Germany since June but seven goals in his last six Bundesliga games helped him earn a recall. Germany was playing the friendly at the home stadium of his club Stuttgart and fans chanted for Undav long before he came off the bench.

The game seemed to be fizzling out to a draw when he flicked the ball over Ghana's goalkeeper in the 88th minute to give Germany a seventh successive win.

Ghana's Abdul Fatuwu earlier scored on the counter to cancel out Kai Havertz's penalty for Germany.

After Florian Wirtz's spectacular attacking display in Germany's 4-3 win against Switzerland, Germany was expected to score high against an opponent coming off a 5-1 loss to Austria. It ended up being a subdued win in constant driving rain. Nick Woltemade started in one of four German changes but his main impact was heading against the bar in the second half.

Sheinbaum meets FIFA's chief to review Mexico's WC preparations

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Mexico City

Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum met FIFA's President Gianni Infantino to assess preparations for the 2026 World Cup, which will be co-hosted by Mexico, the United States and Canada in June and July.

Sheinbaum said on her social media account that she had breakfast with Infantino at the National Palace "because we are evaluating everything for the upcoming World Cup," adding that "everything is going to be wonderful."

The tournament kicks off on June 11 at the iconic Azteca Stadium in Mexico City with a match between the hosts and South Africa. A friendly match between Mexico and Portugal was held at the Mexico City stadium last



Saturday as part of the World Cup preparations. The event was marred by the death of a fan who fell from the second tier to the ground floor in the VIP box area.

"This inauguration is going to be historic, exceptional," said Sheinbaum while holding a FIFA pennant along-

Iraq faces Bolivia for 2026 World Cup spot

CARLOS RODRIGUEZ
■ Monterrey (Mexico)

Earlier this month, Iraq coach Graham Arnold was stranded in Fujairah, on the eastern coast of the United Arab Emirates, due to the Mideast war. He wondered if his national team would even be able to compete for one last chance to qualify for the 2026 World Cup.

After travelling a long and winding road to reach Mexico, Arnold and Iraq will seek to return to a World Cup after an absence of 40 years when they face Bolivia in the final of their intercontinental playoff in Monterrey in northern Mexico on Tuesday.

"It's been very difficult being stranded, I'd rather not talk about it, I try to remove all of that from the players' brains because a lot of things are going on in the Middle East," Arnold said Monday in a media conference. "But players know what they're doing, they



seem very relaxed and ready to go." Arnold was with his wife in a hotel in Fujairah after a series of Iranian missiles hit nearby when the war between the United States and Iran began. The Australian coach was able to move to Dubai, but he was unable to join the team for several days.

Iraqi players were also stranded because the country's airspace



was closed, preventing the team from using commercial flights to leave the country. Team officials officially asked FIFA to postpone the playoff match.

"I came from Europe directly to Monterrey, but for the rest of the players who play in the Iraqi local league, they had a long trip, but we had a lot of time to recover from that," said Merchas Doski, who

plays as a left back for Viktoria Plzen, in the Czech first league. "We are fully prepared."

The team also faced visa complications because Mexico does not have an embassy in Iraq and players struggled to obtain the necessary visas to enter the country. But the issue was resolved when the Mexican foreign affairs ministry facilitated visas at other

regional embassies. The team finally arrived in Monterrey on March 21 after a 25-hour journey that included navigating travel restrictions and a stopover in Portugal.

"It has been very tough 20 days for us, but it is an honour and a privilege to be here — I lived in Australia for a long time and I know that qualifying for a World Cup can change a nation," said Arnold, who guided the Socceroos to the round of 16 at the 2022 World Cup.

Since arriving in Mexico, the team has had plenty of time to adjust to the climate and players have practised without incident. They have also been able to fraternise with children from local schools who have visited them during their training sessions.

"They (Mexican fans) have been amazing. It's really fun to see that they cheer us," said Aimar Sher, who plays for Sarpsborg 08 in Norway. (AP)

US soccer team must be en vogue: Leibovitz

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Marietta

The US soccer team must be en vogue: Annie Leibovitz was at training to shoot photos. Leibovitz took photos of four players for an hour on a turf field at Children's Healthcare of Atlanta Training Ground, the practice facility of Major League Soccer's Atlanta United.

Each of the participating players received an autographed book from the 76-year-old photographer. The outlet that will be using the shoot was not disclosed. Six American players also were on a grass field having their photos taken for Vogue.

In addition, during the current training camp, players took part in promotion shots for World Cup rights holders Fox and Telemundo, interviews with TNT Sports, which holds U.S. Soccer Federation rights, and World Cup promotional prepa-



ration for USSF advertising and marketing partners.

Players here who were not at the November training camp also had to be photographed in the new Nike uniforms that will be used at the World Cup.

US coach Mauricio Pochettino said all the activities took away time from focusing on the friendlies against Belgium, a 5-2 loss Saturday,

and against Portugal on Tuesday.

"We need to be fair with the players because the demand of... the media from when they arrived was really intense," he said. "Yesterday they were so tired and they cannot be seen on the training ground because they wanted to rest a little bit. ... The amount of demand(s) for the World Cup make very difficult the preparation for the games."

Pochettino contrasted this training camp with the November matches, a 2-1 win over Paraguay in Chester, Pennsylvania, and a 5-1 rout over Uruguay in Tampa, Florida, and the October games, a 1-1 draw with Ecuador in Austin, Texas, and a 2-1 victory over Australia in Commerce City, Colorado.

"Philadelphia, Tampa, we were focusing to prepare the game, train and focus on this and this and this and this. Or before again in Austin or in Denver," he said.

Inaugural Little Andaman Pro 2026 to kick off surfing season from April 9

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India's elite surfers and stand-up paddlers will vie for top honours in the inaugural Little Andaman Pro 2026 National Surf and SUP Championship to be held in the Andaman and Nicobar Islands from April 9 to 12.

Organised by Surfing Federation of India (SFI), the event will competition in the Senior Division across Surfing and Stand-Up Paddle (SUP) disciplines, and the event will offer the participants some much-needed game time prior to this year's Asian Games.

India secured its first-ever Asian



Games quota at the 2024 Asian Surfing Championships and built on that momentum at the 2025 edition in Mahabalipuram, ultimately securing the maximum allocation of four slots, two each in the men's and women's categories for the Asian

Games in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan. "We are constantly working to give more competition time to our talented athletes across diverse conditions, which is critical for their growth at the international level," said, Arun Vasu, President of SFI.

Leander Paes' decision brings spotlight on sportspersons in politics

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Tennis legend Leander Paes' decision to switch to the BJP after a five-year association with the Trinamool Congress brought back the spotlight on sportspersons in politics on Tuesday. While some rose high to become cabinet ministers, some others garnered mixed results electorally and are still finding their way. PTI takes a glance at some prominent names who made the daring career shift.

Mohammad Azharuddin

The former Indian cricket captain joined Congress in 2009 and became an Lok Sabha member from Moradabad, UP in the same year. But he lost the subsequent Lok Sabha and assembly elections in 2014 and 2023.

After a brief stint as Hyderabad Cricket Association chief, Azhar was drafted in as a cabinet minister in Revanth Reddy's dispensation in Telangana, holding the portfolio of Minister for Public Enterprises & Minority Welfare.



Former tennis player Leander Paes during his joining ceremony at the BJP headquarters in New Delhi on Tuesday

Navjot Singh Sidhu

The former India opener worked in multiple parties — BJP, Congress and his very own Aawaz-e-Punjab. He won the 2004 and 2009 general elections on a BJP ticket. But in 2017, he joined Congress and won the assembly election from Amritsar East. In the 2022 State polls he lost to his AAP rival from the same constituency. Right now, he is on a political sabbatical.

Rajyavardhan Singh Rathore:

The ace shooter, who fetched India's

first-ever shooting silver in Olympics, joined BJP in 2013 and was elected to Lok Sabha in the 2014 general elections from Jaipur. He won in the 2019 polls as well. In 2023, he shifted to State politics and won the election that year, subsequently resigning from LS.

Saina Nehwal

The former World Number 1 and London Olympics bronze winning badminton ace joined the BJP in 2020 along with her sister but is yet to try her fortunes in elections.

Gautam Gambhir

The two-time World Cup winner and the current coach of India's cricket team entered politics through BJP in 2019. In the same year, he won the general election from East Delhi. But in 2024, he moved away from active politics to revive his sporting career as a cricket coach.

Kirti Azad

The 1983 World Cup-winner first entered politics through BJP and won an assembly and Lok Sabha election from Darbhanga, Bihar. But in 2015, Azad was suspended by BJP for his tiff with senior leader Arun Jaitley and he moved to Congress later in 2019. In 2021, he moved to Trinamool Congress, and returned to the lower house through a victory from the Bardhaman-Durgapur constituency in West Bengal.

Vinesh Phogat-Bajrang Punia:

The accomplished and equally controversial wrestlers joined the Congress party together in 2024 after agitating aggressively against the then Wrestling Federation of India chief Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh.

Antonee Robinson worried whether US national team would see a return of Jedi

RONALD BLUMAP ■ Marietta

Antonee Robinson worried whether the US would see a return of Jedi.

Self-nicknamed the "Star Wars" character by himself as a kid, Robinson had not played for the national team from November 2024 until Saturday's 5-2 loss to Belgium because of lingering pain following right knee surgery last May 27.

"It just seemed like there was kind of no light at the end of the tunnel," he said on the eve of his return.

A 28-year-old left back, Robinson is a key player for Fulham in the Premier League and when healthy a first-choice starter for the US

Robinson assisted on Weston McKennie's opening goal against Belgium with the first corner kick Robinson ever took for the Americans.

"He needs to build," US coach Mauricio Pochettino said. "I want to see him in his best. And that is the challenge from here to the World Cup to arrive with all the players in their best performance, to perform in the way we believe they can perform."

Robinson was raised in Liverpool. His father, Marlon, was born in England,

grew up in White Plains, New York, and was on Duke's soccer team from 1981-84. Antonee was a member of Everton's youth academy, made his professional debut in 2017 in the League Cup in August 2017 while on loan to Bolton and his Premier League debut in 2020 with Fulham.

His first appearance for the US was in 2018. A chess player and a pianist, he strikes his own chord in the US locker room.

"He's into a lot of different things, that's for sure," American captain Tim Ream said. "His

brain works very differently to a lot of ours."

Robinson didn't dress for Fulham's opener on August 18 and was a second-half sub in the Cottagers' second and third games. He had a 23-day layoff, went the distance in a League Cup match on September 23 and had a Premier League substitute appearance five days later. He then sat out until December 13, losing his starting spot to Ryan Sessegnon.

Sessegnon's hamstring injury allowed Robinson back into the starting lineup.

"I've been able to get myself in pretty good shape back at the club," Robinson said. "I've been available for everything. I haven't missed any training sessions and I've been sort of progressing with how I feel in myself

and then translating that to playing games and getting back up to, you know, being sharp and being ready."

As his rehab kept extending in the fall, Robinson was aware that the World Cup was nearing and he might run out of time.

"No sort of certainty on my end that I was going to be fit and available," he recalled, explaining how he widened his search for advice.

"Seeking outside help for my rehab and different opinions and stuff on how I could change up what I was doing to get my physical condition a lot better," he said. "A series of injections and things like that to try and let it heal." (AP)



Connolly shines to power PBKS win over GT

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mullanpur

Young southpaw Cooper Connolly marked his IPL debut with a decisive 44-ball 72 after Yuzvendra Chahal's artistry with the ball to power Punjab Kings to a three-wicket victory over Gujarat Titans here on Tuesday.

After PBKS opted to field first, leg-spinner Chahal (2/28 in 4 overs) brought his years of experience to the fore to stymie GT in the middle overs and limit them to 162/6.

Seamer Vijaykumar Vyshak grabbed 3/34 for PBKS.

After almost losing their way with the bat due to Prasidh Krishna's (3/29 in 4 overs) excellent bowling, PBKS completed the chase of 163 with five balls to spare. Connolly and Prabhsimran Singh (37 off 24 balls) laid the foundation for the win with a 76-run partnership for the second wicket.

Earlier, skipper Shubman Gill (39 off 27 balls) and Jos Buttler (38 off 33 balls) were the chief contributors for GT in an insipid batting display. PBKS' start was not good

as Kagiso Rabada cramped Priyansh Arya for room with his pace and line to dismiss the opener after debutant fast bowler Ashok Sharma went back a few steps to pull off a good catch at midwicket.

Connolly and Prabhsimran then meant business as they went about their task in a professional manner to keep their team ahead, the two hitting a flurry of fours and sixes to flatten the GT bowlers.

Rashid Khan gave GT hope with the wicket of Prabhsimran, the batter failing to clear Prasidh Krishna at long-on.

Shreyas Iyer pulled Ashok Kumar's short balls over deep square-leg for two sixes but, shortly after taking a solid hit off his partner Connolly's shot, the PBKS captain flicked a Prasidh Krishna half-volley to Washington Sundar at deep mid-wicket.

Sundar removed Nehal Wadhera, and Krishna dismissed Shashank Singh and Marcus Stoinis in quick succession to bring GT back into contention.

But Connolly was there to



see PBKS home, hitting five sixes and as many fours during his knock.

Earlier, sent into bat, Gill dealt in boundaries as the side raced to 35 in three overs.

Gill looked in sublime touch as he picked the gaps at will to score at a good clip, forcing PBKS skipper Shreyas Iyer to effect a bowling change and introduce the tall Marco Jansen (1/20 in 4 overs) into the attack.

The move paid dividends straightaway as left-arm pacer Jansen got Sai Sudharsan (13) to slice one straight towards mid-off where Shreyas completed a simple catch.

Sudharsan appeared to be attempting to loft the ball over mid-on, giving the PBKS a much-needed break-through in the fourth over.

That brought Jos Buttler to the crease and the Englishman, coming off a disappointing T20 World Cup campaign, got off the mark in style, caressing Vyshak Vijaykumar through cover for a boundary, the shot giving the batter a lot of con-

fidence moving forward.

Buttler employed the cut shot against a short and wide Jansen delivery to get a four through backward point and then struck the game's first six when he lofted Vyshak straight down the ground, as the seamer failed to land his attempted slower ball in the right area.

GT ended the powerplay at 54 for one, with PBKS having pulled things back a bit after leaking plenty in the first three overs.

Chahal came on in the eighth over and the leg-spinner, who has a good record against Gill having dismissed the opener three times in previous IPL match-ups, had his man once again as the batter holed out to deep midwicket after setting him up for a big score.

Chahal bowled one slower through the air and while Gill got the elevation, he did not get distance to clear the rope.

New man Glenn Phillips smashed Chahal over long-on for a maximum, and then, Buttler smoked a short Xavier Bartlett ball over mid-on for a six.

Ganguly backs BCCI on Test venues

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

Former India captain and Cricket Association of Bengal President Sourav Ganguly would love to host as many Tests as possible at the Eden Gardens but he is also "happy" to see the traditional format reach other venues like Guwahati and Ranchi.

Unveiling Team India's home season for 2026-27, the BCCI last week left out traditional venues like Kolkata and Mumbai from the marquee Border-Gavaskar Trophy against Australia, scheduling matches in Nagpur, Chennai, Guwahati, Ranchi and Ahmedabad from January 21 to February 25 next year.

Reacting to the move, Ganguly said Eden Gardens has got its fair share of games.

"It's always great to have big Test matches back at Eden Gardens. As the president of the CAB and being a former player, I would like to host Test matches here, but we got the Test against South Africa, then there were T20 World Cup games and the Indian Premier League fixtures," Ganguly said on the sidelines of the book launch 'Miracle At Eden' by Sportstar.

"As much as you would like to host matches at the Eden, it is important to understand

that it has to go to other venues as well," he added.

India's 2026-27 home season is a packed one, featuring series against West Indies, Sri Lanka, Zimbabwe and Australia across formats. Kolkata and Mumbai will host only white-ball matches.

But Guwahati, which made its Test debut in November 2025, will host its second Test in just over a year's time, while Ahmedabad's Narendra Modi Stadium also returns as a venue after hosting the

WANKHEDE LAST HOSTED A TEST IN NOV 2024, WHILE EDEN GARDENS STAGED ONE AGAINST SOUTH AFRICA IN NOV IN THE YEAR GONE BY

West Indies in October last season.

The Wankhede last hosted a Test in November 2024, while Eden Gardens staged one against South Africa in November in the year gone by.

In the BCCI's calendar, Kolkata (January 3, 2027) and Mumbai (January 9, 2027) have been allotted ODIs against Zimbabwe, while Delhi will host Sri Lanka for the first ODI on December 13 this year. The perceived sidelining of traditional centres has divided opinions.



Hockey: 29 teams set for sub-junior women's nationals

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Ranchi

A total of 29 teams will compete across three divisions when the 16th Hockey India Sub Junior Women's National Championship begins here with five matches on Wednesday.

The tournament will run till April 12 and the participating teams will compete across Division 'A', Division 'B', and Division 'C', in a promotion and relegation format introduced last year.

While Division 'A' teams will vie for the championship title, the top two teams from Divisions 'B' and 'C' will earn promotion. The bottom two teams in Divisions 'A' and 'B' will face relegation for the next edition.

Division 'A' features 12 teams divided into four pools, with the knockout stages scheduled from April 9, culminating in the Final on April 12.

The host side Hockey Jharkhand headlines Pool A and will be joined by Bihar (BSSA) and Maharashtra.

Pool B includes Odisha, Punjab, and Andhra Pradesh. In Pool C, Haryana, Madhya Pradesh, and Manipur will compete, while Pool D comprises Mizoram, Uttar Pradesh Hockey, and Chhattisgarh.

Division 'B' will follow a league format from April 1 to 6, with teams split into two pools. Pool A features Delhi, Dadra & Nagar Haveli and Daman & Diu, Tamil Nadu, Bengal, and Assam. Pool B includes Chandigarh, Uttarakhand, Gujarat, Karnataka, and Himachal Pradesh.

Division 'C' will also be played in a league format from April 1 to 4.

Pool A consists of Kerala, Telangana, and Goa, while Pool B includes Jammu & Kashmir, Puducherry, Rajasthan, and Tripura. Matches will be held at the Marang Gomke Jaipal Singh Astro turf Hockey Stadium in Ranchi.

Pressure on Pant as LSG face Delhi Capitals

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow

Lucknow Super Giants (LSG) captain Rishabh Pant will have little room for error in a critical year as his side begins its IPL 2026 campaign against a well-rounded Delhi Capitals (DC) here on Wednesday.

Pant could not deliver as a leader and frontline batter in his first year at LSG. Injuries to key players, especially fast bowlers, made his job a lot tougher.

This season, he has a fully fit squad at his disposal that has been bolstered by the addition of old warhorse Mohammed Shami and Anrich Nortje.

Injury prone pace sensation Mayank Yadav has worked hard on his fitness over the past 12 months and LSG would be hoping that he repays the



strong faith that franchise had reposed in him.

Pacer Mohsin Khan too is making a comeback from injury while Prince Yadav has also impressed with his medium pace in the nets thus far.

Mystery spinner Digvesh Singh Rathie made a name for himself in his debut season and would be looking to build on the massive gains that he made 12 months ago.

Compared to the bowling

department, the batting has a more settled look with Mitchell Marsh and Aiden Markram forming one of the most lethal opening pairings in the IPL.

Pant, who could not make an impact at number four for majority of last season before slamming a hundred at number three, is set to bat in the top-order with Nicholas Pooran to follow at number four.

LSG take on a side that should have made the play-offs last year after a promising beginning. Delhi Capitals tried as many as seven opening combinations last year and this season they are confident of more stability in the top-order.

KL Rahul is certain to open the innings but there is not enough clarity on his partner. The options are Prithvi Shaw, Abhishek Porel and Pathum Nissanka.

Huge expectations from Green within IPL, Australia; he has to balance: McDonald

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Sydney

Cameron Green is dealing with huge expectations both in the IPL and in the Australian cricket set-up but the all-rounder has what it takes to balance it out for a career that "will trend upwards", his national head coach Andrew McDonald has said.

Kolkata Knight Riders'

skipper Ajinkya Rahane's remark on a currently injured Green not bowling in the IPL match against Mumbai Indians had created a mild controversy on his fitness status.

Later, Cricket Australia clarified that the KKR management is "fully aware" of the 26-year-old's back niggles, which mandates him to be away from bowling for a period 10-12 days.

"There's huge expectation within the IPL, and there's huge expectation with any all-rounder that shapes an Australian team. It's not unfair, but there is an expectation

around all-rounders that they contribute in a certain way," McDonald told to SEN Radio.

Keeping in mind his all-round prowess, Green was bought by KKR for an eye-watering ₹25.20 crore, making him the most expensive overseas buy ever in the IPL.

"It's almost like they want them to average 45 with the bat and average less than 30 with the ball. And there's been very few that do that. I'm sure that his career will trend upwards," McDonald said.

"We know he's good enough. He's just got to balance out all those expectations, and in particular,

playing all three formats, which is a significant challenge for any cricketer," he added.

However, McDonald said Green's fragile fitness will not be held against him when it comes to considering him as an all-format player, particularly in Tests, for Australia.

"I think the answer to that is, yes (all-format player). I've

got to talk to the selectors around that. But if you look at the last (Australian) team, Usman (Khawaja) has retired, and he vacates the No. 5 position," the head coach said. "But you've got (Beau) Webster and Green that potentially can play in the same team, so that gives us incredible flexibility. But I think he's (Green) good enough.



RCB players clear about their roles: Krunal Pandya

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

The atmosphere in the Royal Challengers Bengaluru camp is much calmer than last year and players have a lot more understanding of their roles this season, says Krunal Pandya.

RCB won the Indian Premier League trophy for the first time in 18 years in 2025 and Pandya was the Man-of-

the-Match in the final against Punjab Kings at Ahmedabad, returning 4-0-17-2 as RCB won the contest by six runs.

"I feel that this year there is a much calmer atmosphere. Last year it was a new team, and everyone got to know each other. This year many players understand their roles and each other's strengths and weaknesses," Pandya said in a release by the franchise.

Pickleball Kingdom launches first court in India

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

USA-based Pickleball Kingdom has launched its first court in India, a state of the art rooftop facility in the national capital.

Pickleball Kingdom operates at more than 400 locations in the United States and considering the enormous potential, it is aggressively looking to expand its operations in India via local partner BAQ Wizards Private Limited.

Pickleball Kingdom's first ever facility in the country has been built in Okhla in partnership with real estate developer Max Estates.

The rooftop court provides a unique, high-energy playing experience in the heart of New Delhi, welcoming visitors to one of the fastest-growing sports in the world.



Pickleball Kingdom's promoters in India, Bhanu Gulati and Anuj Duggal, are bullish about the sport's growth in a cricket-crazy country.

"Pickleball is more than just a sport — it's a movement that brings

people together. We're excited to bring the Pickleball Kingdom experience to India," they said in a joint statement.

Sooryavanshi dominated with his fearless approach: Bangar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Vaibhav Sooryavanshi taking down world class bowlers in his IPL 2026 opening knock was a reflection of his special talent and fearless approach, feels former India batting coach Sanjay Bangar.

The 15-year-old smashed a 15-ball fifty to set up Rajasthan Royals' roaring

win over CSK on Monday.

A year after becoming the youngest to score an IPL hundred, Sooryavanshi took the likes of Matt Henry and Noor Ahmad to the cleaners in his exhilarating knock.

"Vaibhav Suryavanshi was a class apart. He dominated a good bowling attack. He took on Matt Henry, a new ball bowler, who challenges top batters

internationally," Bangar told Star Sports.

"He toyed with Khaleel Ahmed, who swings the ball both ways. He got the better of Anshul Kamboj, known for hitting the deck hard with good length deliveries. He even made life difficult for mystery bowler Noor Ahmad."

Bangar explained what separates the teenager from the rest.

"At the age of 15, he dominated four quality bowlers with his fearless batting and forced them to move away from their strengths. Henry had to bowl slower balls."

"Khaleel had to try different things. He put pressure on all of them. That shows Vaibhav, with his fearless approach, is getting into the minds of established bowlers.



Taiwan boxing champ wins first bout at Asian titles

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Ulaanbaatar (Mongolia)

Lin Yu-ting comfortably won her first international bout since the 2024 Paris Olympics at the Asian championships on Tuesday after World Boxing said she passed a gene test.

Taiwan's first Olympic boxing champion beat Thananya Somnuek of Thailand 5-0 in the round of 16 in the 60-kilogram division. That earned Lin a quarterfinal against division favorite Ayaka Taguchi of Japan.

The 30-year-old Lin wasn't cleared to compete at the Asian titles until less than two weeks ago.

World Boxing took over as the sport's Olympic-level governing body last year, and it implemented a sex eligibility policy last August requiring all fighters to take a one-time genetic test designed to identify the presence of a Y chromosome.

Two-time world champion Lin qualified for the Asian championships in December by defeating compatriot Wu Shih-yi, a 60kg bronze medalist at the Paris Olympics.

